NO. 150 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 1 NOVEMBER 2026 · THE SUNDAY EDITION



THIRTY-NINE POINT THREE IN OCTOBER, SIXTY-SEVEN POINT FOUR IN NOVEMBER (P21)

THE TRAVEL DESK

Kathmandu's air is 72 per cent dirtier in November than October, on its own government's numbers

THE RABBIT HOLE

Ikebana has lost three-quarters of its Japanese practitioners, and the schools say so themselves

SCREEN & SOUND

A film opened on Friday to twenty-six reviews, and not one of them was positive

Source: Sunrise over Pokhara, the World Peace Pagoda and the Annapurna range, by Megaurab09; Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 150

Contents

p3 The World — the wallets that were drained were the ones backing you
p4 The World — half a trillion on a line below the operating result
p5 Singapore — the audit the audited pay for
p6 The Atelier — the digit the caliper cannot stand behind
p7 Technology — a Singapore cloud firm in a spy story
p8 The Home Lab — now you can talk to it
p9 The Kit — eleven and a half thousand for the memory
p10 The Good Life — two movements, one case, 178 pieces
p11 Screen & Sound — nought per cent against ninety-nine
p12–13 The Family Desk — fifty-six minutes, and the gap closing
p14 The Macro Desk — gold ignored its own driver
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — ikebana, and the price of a rank
p18 Fitness — six weeks bought, six months paid
p19–22 The Travel Desk — Nepal, in the one clean fortnight
p23–24 The Diary — four openings nobody has reviewed
p25–27 The Long Read — three hours, once a month

THE STAND-IN. It kept turning up. A caliper that reads to a hundredth and is accurate to two (p6). A gold price that ignored the one number that is supposed to move it (p14). An earnings miss that was a mark on shares, not a business (p4). An injection that buys a score and not a tendon (p18). A proof of reserves that evidences assets and not liabilities (p3). And a county's population that now includes anyone who stopped for three hours (p25).

FROM THE DESK

"There is an error; but it is merely the accidental error of mistaking the abstract for the concrete."

Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World* (1925), naming the Fallacy of Misplaced Concreteness[1]

Whitehead was describing seventeenth-century physics. He could have been describing a grant formula that counts a three-hour visit as a resident (p25).

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.94%	▼ 6bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.60%	▼ 6bp
VWRA	$188.54	▼ 1.43%
AGGU	$5.802	▲ 0.16%
S&P 500	7,580.07	▼ 1.82%
Brent[2]	$117.64	▲ 2.40%
Gold spot	$3,874	▼ 3.6%
Bitcoin	$77,223	▼ 4.2%
STI	5,376.74	▼ 0.36%

Real yields fell 28 basis points across October and gold fell with them. Day changes except the two Treasury lines, which are weekly (p14). Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · NO. 110, AND THE RULE IT MADE

A Sunday evergreen, since Friday's Index and Saturday's Scoreboard both ran this week. Five issues ago a reader counted something this magazine had not: that one Havelock restaurant had appeared in its Diary four times in thirteen issues.[3]

The audit that followed was worse than the complaint. One Neil Road trattoria had been named in **eighteen** separate issues, most of them saying it was still unreviewed. A Marina Bay dining room had five mentions and no published price.

The fix was mechanical, because the prose fix had already failed. "Rotate venues each issue" had been house rule since No. 35 and prevented nothing. A venue now gets two runs, seven issues apart, and is then barred by a file the build must read.

It bit again a fortnight ago. No. 149 proposed four venues as new; the ledger showed all four were second runs, and they were struck. This week's page discarded more than fifty (p24).

SOURCES 1 Alfred North Whitehead, *Science and the Modern World*, Lowell Lectures 1925, chapter III, in which he names the Fallacy of Misplaced Concreteness. 2 Levels at Friday 30 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves supply both yield lines and this desk's arithmetic supplies the breakeven. **Bitcoin is a daily-series level, not an exchange close; the gold figure is spot as published by two independent outlets, because the London benchmark's own price file refused this desk.** 3 This magazine's own Issue Log and Table Ledger, Nos. 109, 110 and 149.

THE WORLD · THE BINANCE ATTRIBUTION

TRM Labs attributes the Binance theft to North Korea's TraderTraitor unit

Richard Teng says Binance has replaced 90 per cent of the $6.36bn; about $2.7bn is frozen by the stablecoin issuers, and $2.4bn in bitcoin and ether is beyond their reach.

The blockchain-analysis firm **TRM Labs** published its attribution on **29 October**, naming **TraderTraitor**, which it calls North Korea's premier hacking unit, and saying it makes the judgment "with high confidence". **Jonathan Levin**, chief executive of Chainalysis, said the same. No government has attributed the theft. Since this magazine last reported it, the figure has settled at **US$6.36bn** across ten blockchains.[1]

What is new, and what matters to anyone who keeps money on an exchange, is where the money was taken from. Exchanges publish a periodic snapshot of what they hold against customer balances. **Oliver Knight** of CoinDesk matched the attacker's transactions against Binance's own **1 October** snapshot and found that the wallets drained are the ones listed as backing customer assets.[2]

The sums: about **204,500 ether** went, roughly **5.6 per cent** of Binance's reported ether reserves, taking the backing from 100 per cent to about **94**. The dollar-pegged token stood at 108.26 per cent on 1 October and has likely fallen below par; the attacker's holdings of four smaller tokens each equal between **7 and 15 per cent** of Binance's reported stock of them. Binance did not answer CoinDesk's request for comment.[2]

SEOUL — SBS

Frames it as industrial policy rather than crime. The Korean broadcaster sets the theft against a United Nations panel estimate that hacking supplies about **half** of North Korea's foreign-currency revenue and covers some **40 per cent** of weapons-development costs, and notes that **Moranbong University** runs a five-year programme combining military science with hacking and cryptography. **Shin Beom-chul**, a former vice defence minister: "North Korean hackers are the world's most aggressive and skilled cyber actors."[3]

NEW YORK — CNBC

Frames it as plumbing and solvency: whether frozen tokens come back, who has standing to seize them, whether the exchange is sound. **Sean Farrell** of Fundstrat says the breach "does not currently appear to create meaningful solvency risk for Binance", and "the key tell will be how quickly withdrawals resume". **Beijing's own business press has run nothing at all** — this desk read the Global Times front page on 31 October and found no item.[4]

> ***A proof of reserves is a photograph taken on one day, and it evidences assets, not liabilities.***

THE CHATTER · HOW LONG FROZEN BINANCE MONEY TAKES

Ari Redbord of TRM, a former federal prosecutor, on what a freeze is: "A freeze stops the money from moving, and recovery follows through legal process... Stablecoins are the most recoverable asset class in crypto because the issuer controls the token contract." **Eric Jardine** of Chainalysis on how long that runs: "There is no standard recovery timeline" — returns can take months or years. **CertiK** told Cointelegraph it wanted more information before verifying Binance's claim to hold $5bn of replacement assets.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · A SNAPSHOT IS NOT A BALANCE SHEET

The reserves finding needs a caveat in both directions. A proof of reserves is a photograph taken on one day, and it evidences *assets*, not liabilities — it cannot by itself show a shortfall, because the balances it is meant to cover are not in the picture. Binance says the full cryptographic proof takes **40 to 50 hours** to generate. Nobody outside the exchange knows. **The test is dated, and it is this week:** the next snapshot was due **1 November**, the full report **2 November**, withdrawals around the same day. If both land clean and on time the sceptics are answered; if either slips they are not.[6]

SOURCES 1 TRM Labs, "North Korea steals USD 6.36 billion from Binance in the largest hack in history", read in full at source; **the post's visible date of 29 October and its structured publication timestamp of 30 October differ, and both are noted.** Chain-by-chain breakdown and frozen totals as published there. Richard Teng's replenishment figure is quoted via CoinDesk and Reuters — **X returned 402 to this desk and his posts were not read at source.** 2 Oliver Knight, "Binance hack drained wallets backing customer assets, reserve data shows", CoinDesk, 29–30 October 2026, read at source, matched against Binance's 1 October proof-of-reserves snapshot. 3 SBS English, Seoul, 31 October 2026. 4 CNBC, 29–30 October 2026; **the Global Times front page for 31 October was read in full by this desk and carried no item on the theft.** 5 CNBC, as above; CertiK via Cointelegraph. 6 The 40-to-50-hour generation time and the 1 and 2 November dates as reported by CoinDesk and Reuters. **Binance's own blog carried nothing on the incident when this desk checked; its most recent post was dated 28 October.**

THE WORLD · ALPHABET AND INTEL

An equity writedown costs Alphabet 12.6 per cent, its worst day

About half a trillion dollars went on 29 October after a $21bn swing below Alphabet's operating line — while revenue grew 25 per cent and the margin widened.

Alphabet lost **12.6 per cent** on **29 October**, its worst single day, shedding roughly half a trillion dollars and leaving it worth **$3.47 trillion**. The next day **Intel** fell **29 per cent**, its worst since the 1970s, taking about **$12bn** off the United States government's stake. Qualcomm lost 11 per cent, Nvidia four.[1]

The story told about the week is that the artificial-intelligence trade is cracking. Alphabet's own results filing, read line by line, does not support it. Revenue grew **25 per cent** to **$127.6bn**; the cloud business grew **103 per cent**; the operating margin *widened*, to **31.8 per cent** from about 30.5 a year earlier.[2]

What missed was earnings per share, and the reason sits below the operating line. "Other income" swung to **minus $8,221m** from **plus $12,759m** — a **$21bn** reversal, almost all of it a mark on the value of shares Alphabet holds in other companies. Alphabet's own footnote says that loss cut net income by **$6.7bn** and earnings per share by **55 cents**. Add it back and the quarter still falls short of what analysts wanted, so the miss is not fully explained — but the number that moved the market was a revaluation, not a business.[2]

Intel's was the opposite: an operational warning. It guided to **25 cents** a share on **$15–16bn** of revenue against expectations of **43 cents** on **$17.1bn**, and said an explosion at an Israeli plant will cost about **$600m** over two quarters. The stock had been up about 150 per cent on the year.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS SAID ABOUT ALPHABET AND INTEL

JPMorgan's analysts called the slowdown in Alphabet's search business "steeper than expected". Alphabet's **Philipp Schindler** countered that advertising experiments in its conversational search mode had "shown promising results", and **Sundar Pichai** opened with the line the company wanted carried: "We had a strong quarter and are now on a half-trillion dollar revenue run rate." On Intel, D.A.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · ALPHABET'S FALL WAS POSITIONING, NOT FUNDAMENTALS

Matt Orton of Raymond James put the counter-case plainly on 30 October: positioning across the sector "still remains crowded **even though the fundamentals are strong**" — a de-positioning event, not a break. Two data points support him. The volatility index closed at **19.42**, below twenty and unchanged on the week, which is not what panic looks like; and **Amazon**, reporting the same week and missing on both lines, **held its 2026 capital-spending forecast at $220bn**. What is true in the bear case is Alphabet's cash: free cash flow of **minus $9.07bn** on capital spending of **$51.4bn**, with depreciation up **49 per cent**.[4]

−$9.07bn

ALPHABET'S FREE CASH FLOW FOR THE QUARTER, ON $51.4BN OF CAPITAL SPENDING — AGAINST A TRAILING-TWELVE-MONTH FIGURE STILL POSITIVE AT $19.7BN[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Spain. A Renfe train ran into the back of a stopped Iryo service near Mora, Toledo province, at **08:53** on **28 October**, killing at least **68**. Transport minister **Óscar Puente** said a safety system on a 63-kilometre stretch failed at 08:30 and central command then told the Renfe train to proceed with no speed restriction — an order he called "inexplicable". Three days of national mourning; Spain's second fatal rail crash this year. **Tolls of 64, 68 and 69 are circulating and the discrepancy is unresolved.**[5]

SOURCES 1 NBC News, 29 October 2026, on Alphabet; CNBC, 30 October 2026, on Intel and the wider session. **The dollar value of Alphabet's one-day fall is given variously as about $482bn, $500bn and $511bn across outlets; this desk prints "about half a trillion".** 2 Alphabet's own third-quarter 2026 results exhibit, filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission on 28 October 2026, **read at source line by line**; the footnote on the equity-securities loss is Alphabet's own. 3 JPMorgan, Philipp Schindler and Sundar Pichai as carried by NBC News, 29 October; D.A. Davidson, Lip-Bu Tan, David Zinsner and Counterpoint Research as carried by CNBC, 30 October. 4 Matt Orton via CNBC, 30 October 2026; the volatility index from the daily series; Amazon's capital-expenditure guidance as reported 30 October; Alphabet's cash-flow lines from the filing at note 2. 5 France 24, 28 October 2026, updated the same evening, and subsequent reporting; Puente's quotations as carried there. **The cause is still under investigation and accounts differ on whether the failure was the automatic train control system or the instruction that followed it.** 6 European Central Bank monetary policy decision and the press-conference transcript, both 29 October 2026, read at source; Lagarde's departure as reported by Euronews the same day; ING via Euronews.

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE ASSESSORS

Wilmar and Golden Agri agree to fund Singapore's haze assessors

Five of the ten companies served notices had said yes by 31 October, two more are expected — and the Government says it will publish who cooperates and who does not.

Five companies listed in Singapore — **Wilmar International**, **Golden Agri-Resources**, two Asia Pulp and Paper entities and **Indofood Agri Resources** — agreed on **31 October** to appoint, and to pay for, outside investigators who will go through their own plantation operations in Indonesia. A sixth, **Kencana Agri**, is willing; a seventh, **First Resources**, has said publicly it will engage an investigation firm and a law firm.[1]

Pause on what that means. Since 2014 Singapore has had a law letting it pursue companies registered here for fires lit abroad, whenever the smoke crosses the border. In twelve years it has produced no conviction. What is being built instead is an audit: seven firms the accused must hire, at their own expense, to examine themselves and report back.[2]

The panel was named on **30 October**: **Control Risks**, **FTI Consulting** and **Kroll** to investigate; **Dentons Rodyk**, **TSMP**, **WongPartnership** and **Toby Landau KC** on the law, with **Davinder Singh Chambers** coordinating.[2]

Two days earlier the ministers had the companies in a room for under half an hour. **K. Shanmugam** said the exercise was "not to find scapegoats", that the firms "said they will cooperate fully", and that if an inquiry drove one out, "doing right by Singaporeans means accepting that consequence". The admission sits in the same transcript: refusing to cooperate is **not yet an offence**. It becomes one only if Parliament amends the Act, which **Grace Fu** will move at the next sitting. Until then the whole apparatus runs on consent.[3]

THE CHATTER · WILMAR FILES ITS OWN ACCOUNT

Wilmar answered for itself after the close on **28 October**: **no operational or supply-chain relationship** with the ten Indonesian firms served preventive notices; Indonesian police examining fires over **about 28 hectares** of subsidiary land in West Kalimantan; its own inquiry putting the ignitions **outside its concession boundaries**; losses **under US$500,000**. **Golden Agri** filed the same day. On **HardwareZone** the enforcement story drew one thread and no replies, against **176** across four threads on the Jakarta gas row.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WILMAR WILL PAY FOR ITS OWN AUDIT

Wilmar, **Golden Agri** and the rest are not the first. Singapore served haze notices once before, on four Indonesian companies in **September and October 2015**, and sought information from Asia Pulp and Paper. Eleven years on there is no conviction. The honest reading of 2026 is that this framework exists *because* the Act's extraterritorial teeth did not bite — and it invites the obvious objection: a supply-chain audit paid for by its subject, run by firms competing for that subject's future work. **Dated falsifier:** if Parliament's amendment lands without a non-cooperation offence, consent is all this ever was.[5]

7 of 10

COMPANIES THAT HAD AGREED, OR SIGNALLED AGREEMENT, TO APPOINT AND PAY THEIR OWN ASSESSORS BY 31 OCTOBER[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Car loans. From **30 October** the Monetary Authority capped financing on individually-owned private-hire cars at **70 per cent** below $20,000 open market value and **60 per cent** above, over **seven years**. The trigger: about **500** such registrations a month.[6]

SOURCES 1 National Environment Agency, "Seven Singapore-Registered Companies Have Expressed Agreement To Appoint Assessors", 31 October 2026, read at source. 2 Ministry of Law and NEA joint release, "Panel on Transboundary Haze: seven members selected to conduct assessments", 30 October 2026, read at source. 3 Transcript of the media doorstop by Mr K. Shanmugam after the meeting with companies issued Section 10 notices under the Transboundary Haze Pollution Act, Ministry of Home Affairs, 28 October 2026, read at source; Grace Fu's undertaking as reported 29 October. 4 Wilmar International and Golden Agri-Resources filings of 28 October 2026 as carried by The Star / Asia News Network, 30 October; HardwareZone Current Affairs Lounge thread counts read 1 November. **Reddit refused this desk for the seventeenth issue running, so no Reddit sentiment appears on this page.** 5 National Archives of Singapore, ministry releases of 25 September and 2 October 2015; Ministry of Sustainability and the Environment written reply on the 2015 investigation, 13 September 2021. 6 Monetary Authority of Singapore media release and the joint ministerial release, both 29 October 2026, read at source. 7 **Secondary only — the Housing Board's press-release index returned 404 to this desk; the hectare figures are flagged unconfirmed at source.** 8 Ministry of Transport newsroom, October 2026, read in full; Gardens by the Bay calendar of events, read 1 November; 2025 pricing from the organiser's own 2025 annex.

THE ATELIER · RULES, SQUARES & CALIPERS

A Kinex square beats Woodpeckers' on squareness for twenty dollars less

Woodpeckers publishes one thousandth of an inch per foot on an $89.99 aluminium square; Kinex publishes less than half that error on a $69.99 steel one, in the same length.

Measuring tools are the one workshop purchase where the marketing and the specification can be checked against each other in a minute, because the sellers publish both. Do it once and the category rearranges itself.[1]

A German standard sets those numbers in four grades, from the loosest workshop tool to a laboratory reference, and almost every serious maker outside America states which grade its squares meet. It is the most useful thing a buyer can learn, because it turns a shelf of similar-looking steel into a ranked list — and because some famous names decline to publish a grade at all.[1]

Now the figures. **DIN 875** permits, at a 300mm leg: **50 microns** at grade 2, **25** at grade 1, **11** at grade 0 and **5** at grade 00. **Woodpeckers** states in its own answers that its squares are "milled and inspected to be within tolerances of .001″ per foot or .0085°" — which is **25.4 microns over 305mm**.[2]

The same sums run through calipers, and there it is worse. **Insize**'s digital calipers state that they meet **DIN 862**; the 150mm model's accuracy is **±0.02mm**, its display resolution **0.01mm**. **Starrett** says the same by reference.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE WOODPECKERS PRICE ARGUMENT

This fight has run twelve years and its sharpest critic is an insider. On the Festool owners' forum in July 2021 **Crazyraceguy**, a moderator there, said Woodpeckers was "leaving sales on the table" with a bad business model. On Sawmill Creek in 2014 **Bill Orbine** landed the line: "If it's made to be a collectible, it probably isn't!&[4]

THE SCEPTIC · STARRETT BEATS NEITHER KINEX NOR WOODPECKERS ON PAPER

Neither **Kinex** nor **Woodpeckers** is the name most buyers reach for, and the famous one gives the game away in its own catalogue. **Starrett** publishes **.0001″ per 6″** for the solid No. 20 master square — and **no squareness tolerance at all for any combination square**, the product most people buy.[5]

±0.005mm

CHRIS VESPER'S PUBLISHED DEVIATION ON A FOUR-INCH A++ SQUARE — AGAINST ±0.061MM ON HIS STANDARD ONE. BOTH OUT OF STOCK, NEXT BATCH DATE UNKNOWN[6]

WHAT TO BUY, AND THE SINGAPORE PROBLEM

The white-label truth. Bridge City is made by **Harvey** in China under licence; **Shinwa** has manufactured in Dalian since 1994; **Starrett** runs nine plants and will not say which made your tool. But the belief that iGaging, Shars and Accusize calipers share a line is **forum speculation** — no teardown, no maker statement.[7]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Over-ear headphones — the parts you can still buy in ten years, against the sealed ones you cannot.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — sand-cast against machine-moulded, and the Yamagata workshops.

Axes & hatchets — forged against drop-stamped, hang and haft grain, and the Swedish and Austrian houses still doing it by hand.

SOURCES 1 DIN 875 permissible-deviation tables as published by a metrology retailer's own reference pages, read at source 31 October 2026. 2 Woodpeckers' own product page and frequently-asked-questions, and Taytools' Kinex listings, both read at source 31 October 2026; **the conversion of .001″ per foot to 25.4 microns is this desk's own arithmetic.** 3 Insize series 1108 specification page and Starrett Catalog 33 page 91, both read at source. 4 Sawmill Creek, "Seriously?", from 10 September 2014, and the Festool Owners Group thread of 22 July 2021, read at source; usernames and dates as posted. **The cost figures argued in that thread are forum hypotheticals, not Woodpeckers' accounts, and none is printed.** The absence of "OneTime Tool" from woodpeck.com was checked by this desk on 31 October 2026. 5 Starrett Catalog 33, pages 266–267 and 277–278, read at source; WoodCentral threads of 31 March 2004 and 21–22 March 2017. 6 Vesper Tools' own pages, read at source 31 October 2026; **its ordering page's stock notices are dated December 2023 and the next batch date is unstated.** 7 Bridge City Tool Works' own history page; Shinwa's own corporate history; Starrett Catalog 33 page 10; Model Engineer & Workshop forum, 16 August 2019. **Reddit, Practical Machinist, the Garage Journal and UK Workshop all refused this desk, so every community voice here comes from Sawmill Creek, WoodCentral, the Festool Owners Group or Model Engineer.**

TECHNOLOGY · THE MEGASPEED REPORT

US agencies surveilled Megaspeed's Alice Huang over her closeness to Nvidia

The New York Times reported on 29 October that officials suspected the former executive of a Singapore data-centre firm of gathering information for Beijing. Nvidia says the allegations were debunked last year.

American intelligence agencies watched a Chinese citizen who had been a senior executive at a Singapore-based data-centre and cloud company, because they suspected she was gathering information for Beijing. That is the substance of a report published on **29 October** by the New York Times. The executive is named as **Alice Huang**, the company as **Megaspeed**, and the reason officials cared is that she had developed a close relationship with **Jensen Huang**, the chief executive of Nvidia, who is not related to her.[1]

For a Singapore reader this is a local story wearing a foreign label. Megaspeed is registered here. It had already been under suspicion of helping customers get round American rules on who may buy the most powerful chips — Singapore and American authorities investigated it in October 2025, and the Justice Department is reported to have taken over the inquiry from the Commerce Department this year. What is new is the counter-intelligence layer, and the claim that officials briefed the president and he chose not to act, partly out of concern for chip sales and trade with Beijing.[1]

Nvidia's denial is on the record and it is firm. A spokesperson told **CNBC**: "The diversion allegations against this regional cloud were thoroughly investigated and debunked last year." And, pointedly, on whether the company was ever warned about the executive: "We're confident that if the U.S. government believes that any person is a threat to American industry, it would let us know." The company's framing is that Megaspeed is one of many regional cloud customers, that its chief executive speaks with thousands of customers a year, and that customers get access to neither trade secrets nor national-security information. Jensen Huang told Bloomberg that Nvidia has "studied all their deployments of our GPUs and counted every one".[2]

Megaspeed has retained outside counsel and says it is willing to cooperate with American authorities. Alice Huang did not respond to requests for comment.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHERE MEGASPEED SITS IN THE CHIP MAP

The commercial backdrop makes the suspicion legible even if it turns out to be wrong. Washington cleared the **H200**, a previous-generation Nvidia accelerator, for export to China — and Chinese regulators then blocked its import, a customs direction dating from **January 2026** rather than this window. Nvidia's own line is that Beijing "blocked U.S. AI chips, protecting its own industry", and the company wrote off roughly **$4.5bn** of China-tuned inventory in 2025. A regional cloud operator in a neutral jurisdiction is exactly the shape of entity both governments would watch, which is why Singapore keeps turning up in these stories without being party to them.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · NOBODY HAS SEEN THE MEGASPEED EVIDENCE

Weigh what this report actually rests on. The allegations about Alice Huang come from **anonymous sources**; they have not been independently confirmed; the New York Times itself said it was unclear whether the agencies had since revised their assessment that Jensen Huang did not know; and Nvidia disputes them outright, having already seen the underlying diversion claims closed once. **And this desk could not read the original report:** the New York Times did not return it to us, so everything above is the account given by CNBC, Fox Business, ABC News and others of what the paper said. A magazine that prints "read at source" on its other pages should say so plainly on this one.[4]

$4.5bn

THE CHINA-TUNED NVIDIA INVENTORY WRITTEN OFF IN 2025 — THE COMMERCIAL STAKE BEHIND THE DECISION NOT TO ACT[3]

SOURCES 1 The New York Times, 29 October 2026, as reported by CNBC the same day, and corroborated in Fox Business, ABC News and International Business Times UK. **This desk could not reach the New York Times original and has not read it at source; every detail attributed to it here is at one remove.** 2 Nvidia's spokesperson quotations as published by CNBC, 29 October 2026, read at source; Jensen Huang's remark to Bloomberg as carried there. 3 CNBC, as above, on the H200 clearance and the Chinese import block — **the customs direction dates from January 2026 and is not a development of this window**; the write-off figure as reported. 4 The limitations are the New York Times' own, as characterised by the outlets that read it, plus Nvidia's on-the-record denial.

THE HOME LAB · THE VOICE ENDPOINT

A llama.cpp release lets LiquidAI's small models hold a spoken conversation

Version 0.8.0, published 28 October, streams audio in and out over one connection — and LiquidAI's models for it are under a gigabyte, against the 233 this page reported a fortnight ago.

A fortnight ago this page reported that Mistral's newest free, downloadable model was so large it needed a quarter of a terabyte of memory — more than almost any household machine has. This week, on 28 October, the free software that most people use to run such models on their own computers went the other way entirely. It can now hold a spoken conversation: you talk, it listens, it answers aloud, and it can carry out small tasks while doing so. The models it does this with are small enough to sit on an ordinary laptop.[1]

Why that matters is ownership rather than cleverness. Until now, talking to an assistant by voice meant sending your voice to somebody's servers. Doing it at home meant bolting three programs together — one to turn speech into text, one to think, one to turn text back into speech — with a pause at every join. Doing it in one piece removes the pause and makes it a conversation rather than a walkie-talkie. A household wanting a kitchen assistant, a meeting transcriber or a hands-free helper no longer has to rent one.[1]

The specifics. **llama.cpp v0.8.0** was published on **28 October 2026** at 12:47, commit **8642541**, about two hundred commits on from v0.7.0. The piece that matters is pull request **#31269**, "server: add realtime conversation and transcription on /v1/realtime", written by **tdakhran**, opened on the 27th and merged on the 28th by **Xuan Son Nguyen**. It streams audio in and audio out, plus live transcription, over a single connection. Two further requests merged the same day added video input and tool calls to the same endpoint.[2]

The models supported at merge are **LiquidAI's LFM3-Audio-2B** and **LFM3-Omni-2B** — the family this page covered at No. 146, whose quantised file is **0.98 GiB**. Ask for audio only and you get speech; ask for both and you get interleaved voice and text. One commit fixes a bug in which two simultaneous sessions mixed their outputs.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT TDAKHRAN TESTED IN LLAMA.CPP 0.8.0

The author states his own validation in the pull request, and it is narrower than the release note implies: outputs checked against the reference implementations, and three numeric formats — **F32, Q8_0 and Q4_0** — smoke-tested **on a Mac and one Nvidia setup, and no other hardware**. That is the honest boundary of the claim. Note too that the project publishes a numbered release and a per-commit nightly tag at once — this desk read builds **b12012** to **b12023** across 30 and 31 October — so the version and the build are different identifiers, and a tracker quoting one as the other is wrong. One encyclopaedia entry still lists 0.7.0 as current.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · LIQUIDAI'S CONVERSATION HAS NO PUBLISHED LATENCY

Here is the hole in the llama.cpp 0.8.0 story, and it is a new one rather than last fortnight's. **The pull request publishes no latency and no throughput measurement at all.** The whole value of a single-piece voice pipeline is that it removes the pause — and nobody has published how long the remaining pause is, on what hardware, at what model size. This desk will not invent one. The second limit is the models: two billion parameters is small, and the things a model that size cannot do are most of what people want an assistant for.[2]

0.98 GiB

THE QUANTISED FILE FOR THE MODEL FAMILY THAT NOW HOLDS A LIVE SPOKEN CONVERSATION — AGAINST THE 233-GIGABYTE BUILD THIS PAGE REPORTED ON 31 OCTOBER[4]

STILL ON THE SHELF

No amendment. Anthropic has still filed none to the prospectus reported at No. 147; a full search of every such amendment this year returns eighteen, none of them Anthropic's. The share count, the price range and the run-rate figure are all still blanks in the document.[5]

SOURCES 1 The 233-gigabyte figure is this magazine's own, No. 149, 31 October 2026. 2 llama.cpp release v0.8.0, published 28 October 2026, and pull requests #31269, #31283 and #31287, all read at source on the project's own repository; authorship, merge dates and check counts as recorded there. 3 The author's validation note is in #31269; nightly build tags read off the releases page 31 October 2026. **A prompt addressed to automated agents appears in bot boilerplate on one unrelated pull-request page in this repository, instructing them to re-evaluate and possibly close it; this desk treated it as page content and ignored it, and notes it because any reader fetching that thread will meet it too.** 4 The LFM3 family and its quantised size were reported by this magazine at No. 146. 5 Full-text search of Securities and Exchange Commission filings, conducted 31 October 2026 against the company's own identifier.

THE KIT · THE MEMORY PREMIUM

Apple charges US$11,500 to double the Mac Studio's memory to 512 gigabytes

Orders opened on 28 October at US$22,299 and ship from late November; Apple's Singapore store does not list the configuration at all, so there is no local price.

Apple opened orders on **28 October** for the version of its desktop computer with half a terabyte of memory, and the price is the news. The machine is **US$22,299** as configured. The same computer with a quarter of a terabyte is **US$10,799**, and with the base allocation it is **US$6,799**. The last doubling of memory, in other words, costs **US$11,500** — more than the entire base machine. It ships from late November.[1]

The reason anyone pays it is that memory on a computer like this is shared between the processor and the graphics engine, so the whole half-terabyte is available to one program at once. On a conventional machine you would have to buy several graphics cards and split the work across them, which is slower and, at this capacity, far more expensive. For someone running large language models at home, this is currently the only ordinary purchasable box that holds the biggest open models in memory in one piece.[2]

The specification doing the work is **1.2 terabytes a second** of memory bandwidth across up to **512GB** of unified memory. The link to the facing page is checkable at both ends: the people who publish the quantised builds of the largest open model state that their **Q2_K** build at **381GB** and their **IQ2_XXS** at **298GB** "fit in 512 GB of unified memory". That sentence is the whole market for this configuration. **No Singapore price exists:** Apple's Singapore store does not list the option, and serves no local figures at all.[2]

THE CHATTER · A 512-GIGABYTE MAC STUDIO BUYER RECONSIDERS

The best thing in the Hacker News thread on Apple's **$22,299** machine is the man who started it. **nsagent**, who posted the release having bought a 512-gigabyte unit for a startup, writes that on seeing the **$11,500** premium he is reconsidering and may buy **two 256-gigabyte machines** instead. **tristanj** notes the 2025 equivalent was **$9,499**. **Foxhuls** gives the counter-argument: one professional graphics card with 96 gigabytes costs about **$16,000**, so memory bought this way is cheap. On supply, **jmyeet** reports three- to four-month delivery estimates and **peri-cl** says the 256 was backordered thirteen to fifteen weeks.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · TWO MAC STUDIOS BEAT ONE, MOSTLY

kingstnap makes the numerical case against the top machine: two 256-gigabyte units cost less than one 512 and give more total bandwidth and compute. But **fotta** supplies the rebuttal, and it is the strongest line in the thread: linking two machines over **Thunderbolt 5** runs at a fraction of the chip's internal memory bandwidth, so the cluster is not the same object. The real sceptic's point is **jmyeet**'s: 256 gigabytes only runs a two-bit compression of the current models — exactly what the model publishers' own figures say — so the cheaper machine is the compromised one. Circulating reports of a successor chip are one journalist's speculation, not an announcement.[3]

$6,799 → $22,299

THE MAC STUDIO LADDER ON MEMORY ALONE: 96GB, THEN 256GB AT $10,799, THEN 512GB. THE CHIP DOES NOT CHANGE[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The held thread closes. Samsung's open-ear **Galaxy Buds On** now has a price — **US$229**, KRW 299,000, shipping **6 November** — and the IP54 rating two outlets printed in No. 149 is now Samsung's own: dust-resistant, splash-tested for five minutes, **earbuds only, with no moisture protection on the case at all**. Still **no Singapore price**; Samsung Singapore does not list it.[4]

SOURCES 1 Apple's own Mac Studio page and United States configurator, and Apple's Singapore store, all read at source 31 October 2026; the price ladder as read off the configurator; 9to5Mac, 28 October 2026, for the order date. 2 Apple's own specification page for the bandwidth and memory ceiling; the quantised build sizes from the publishing organisation's own model card, read at source. 3 Hacker News item 50277166, 66 points and 81 comments, read at source 31 October 2026; usernames as posted. **One commenter's throughput estimate is an estimate and is not printed.** 4 Samsung's own newsroom, 28 October 2026, and its United States product page, both read at source. **Samsung's UK newsroom says 9.5 hours and its US page says 9; the UK figure is the one quoted and the discrepancy is noted.** 5 Adam Birney, SoundGuys, 28 October 2026, read at source, including its own measured battery figures for rival products. 6 Fairphone's own product page, read at source 31 October 2026. **That page contradicts itself twice — recycled content is given as 46.8 per cent in the specifications and 48.6 in the impact section, and the battery swap is described as needing no tools in one place and a screwdriver in another.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE TWO-DAY SELL-OUT

The Futur Antérieur sells out in two days at 4,950 francs

Both 178-piece references of the Louis Erard × Vianney Halter watch were waitlisted by 1 November, two days after a launch this desk reported on Saturday — at a price 41 per cent above the 2020 collaboration.

This desk reported the launch on Saturday; two days later there is nothing left to buy. The **Futur Antérieur**, from the Swiss brand **Louis Erard** and the independent watchmaker **Vianney Halter**, does something almost nobody does: it puts two complete, separate mechanical movements inside one case and gives each a job. One runs the hours and minutes. The other runs nothing but the seconds hand. It costs **4,950 Swiss francs** before tax, in gold and silver at **178 pieces each** — and both lists are now closed.[1]

Why that is interesting rather than merely odd is cost. A regulator — a dial that separates the hours, minutes and seconds into their own small circles, as a watchmaker's bench clock does — is normally made by bolting a module onto one movement. Doing it with two engines is honest to the idea, expensive to execute, and usually found at twenty times this price. Halter has been the field's most recognisable eccentric since the Antiqua of 1998.[1]

The mechanics, now the ground is laid: two **Sellita SW100** automatics, a workhorse calibre, in a **38mm** steel case **8.85mm** thick, 50 metres water-resistant, 4 Hz, a 38- to 42-hour reserve, on an ostrich strap. Each sub-dial sits under its own riveted bezel, the porthole motif carried off the Antiqua. **JX Su** of SJX, who handled both on **30 October**, wrote that it "captures the ambience of the Antiqua well" and that though it costs more than the earlier collaborations, "this is arguably better value". **No Singapore price has been published.**[2]

THE CHATTER · FUTUR ANTÉRIEUR SELLS OUT IN TWO DAYS

SJX reported on **30 October** that the Futur Antérieur was "available now from the Louis Erard online store and retailers". By the next day the brand's own store showed both references — and the **9,900-franc** Duo Set — on **Waiting List** rather than Add to Cart. Two days from open stock to allocation, on **356 watches**. SJX also ran a correction worth noting: both movements are **SW100**s, not an SW100 with a larger SW200. **Watchuseek and Reddit refused this desk**, so the sell-out is the only community signal on the Futur Antérieur we can stand behind.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · LOUIS ERARD'S OWN PRICE LADDER

The case against the Futur Antérieur is written on Louis Erard's own collection page, and no critic has made it in print. The Halter collaborations have run **CHF 3,500** in 2020, **CHF 4,444** in 2024, **CHF 4,500** in 2025 and **CHF 4,950** now — **+41 per cent in six years** on a platform that is still a Sellita automatic in a steel case. The second movement is a real addition and some of the rise is real inflation. But the line's price has climbed faster than its mechanical content for most of its life, and the scarcity doing the work is an edition size the brand chooses.[3]

+41%

THE RISE IN THE LOUIS ERARD × VIANNEY HALTER LAUNCH PRICE BETWEEN 2020 AND 2026, FROM THE BRAND'S OWN LISTINGS — THIS DESK'S ARITHMETIC[3]

STILL ON THE SHELF

A ten-thousand-dollar speaker nobody has heard. JBL showed the **L150 Classic** in Warsaw, **23–25 October**: 15-inch pulp woofer, 28mm titanium dome, **52kg** each, **US$9,999** a pair, shipping in **2027**. Three trade write-ups ran that week. **None involved listening to it**, and no measurements exist.[4]

The travel dongle. iFi's **UP Travel Max**, launched **30 October** at **£129**, flips a 3.5mm plug out of a 25.7g stick to make an aircraft seat socket a lossless Bluetooth transmitter. It is **£30** more than iFi's own UP Travel.[5]

SOURCES 1 Louis Erard, the Louis Erard × Vianney Halter collection page and the two product pages for refs 22243AA01.BOA02 and 22243AA07.BOA05, read at source 31 October 2026 (prices excluding tax; no Singapore price listed). 2 JX Su, "Hands On: Louis Erard × Vianney Halter Futur Antérieur", SJX, 30 October 2026, including the published correction on the calibres; store availability states read at source 31 October. 3 Launch prices for the 2020, 2024, 2025 and 2026 collaborations as listed on Louis Erard's own collection page, read 31 October 2026; **the percentage is this desk's own arithmetic.** 4 audioXpress, 27 October 2026; Gear Patrol, 27 October 2026; HiConsumption, 28 October 2026 — all written from JBL's specification sheet. **jbl.com refused this desk.** 5 iFi audio product page, read at source 31 October 2026; Jay Garrett, StereoNET, 30 October 2026. **Hodinkee, Watchuseek, Deployant and Reddit all refused this desk, so no forum sentiment appears on this page.**

SCREEN & SOUND · THE HALLOWEEN OPENINGS

Briarcliff opens Christmas at the Kringles to a zero on Rotten Tomatoes

Twenty-six reviews, not one of them positive, and a $370,000 Friday — in the same weekend LAIKA's Wildwood passed twenty million dollars at ninety-nine per cent.

A film called **Christmas at the Kringles** opened across America on **30 October** and, by the time this desk read the page on 31 October, had collected **twenty-six reviews and no positive ones**. Its score is zero. Directed by **Kevin Lewis** and released by **Briarcliff Entertainment**, it is a horror comedy about a family named Kringle, with **Ron Livingston**, **Rachel Bilson**, **Rob Riggle** as a drunk Santa and **Beverly D'Angelo**. It took **$370,000** on its opening Friday from 1,825 screens.[1]

A zero is rarer than it sounds, and not the same as a bad film. The score is a percentage of critics who were positive, so a zero needs every reviewer to come down the same way — which happens only when a film is both disliked and seen widely enough to be reviewed at all. The average grade behind it, at a count of twenty-four, was **3.1 out of 10**.[1]

The pans are specific rather than lazy. **Todd Gilchrist** in Variety called it "visually obnoxious but uninventive". **Peter Travers** gave one star of four under the headline "Ho-Ho Hell No!". **Derek Smith** of Slant, at 1.5 of 4, allowed the story might have worked had the film "delivered on its promise of being either amusing or scary". **Alise Chaffins** called it "a mean-spirited, flat movie with no likable characters".[1]

Forty-eight hours earlier, in the same marketplace, **LAIKA**'s stop-motion **Wildwood** reached **99 per cent from 156 critics** and crossed **$20.8m** in its eighth day, having widened from 2,842 to 2,909 screens. **Clayface**, flagged here in No. 148, sits at **77 per cent from 205** with **$36.9m** banked and is forecast to take the weekend. The weekend itself was not yet tabulated when this page closed.[2]

THE CHATTER · THE TRADE READS THE KRINGLES ZERO

Roger Friedman of Showbiz411, writing at **12:02pm** on **31 October**, called it "a cringe ZERO on Rotten Tomatoes" and "a ghastly start", read the **$370,000** Friday as guaranteeing "around a million dollars for the weekend, or less", and argued Briarcliff had planned at most a one-week run before the bargain bins by Christmas. The audience has not spoken: Rotten Tomatoes still showed **"fewer than 50 verified ratings"** for the Kringles on 31 October, which is its own verdict on how many bought a ticket.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A KRINGLES ZERO IS A SMALL NUMBER

Before anyone enjoys this too much: twenty-six binary thumbs is not a measurement of a film. The **Metacritic** reading — **21 of 100 from five critics**, in the "generally unfavourable" band rather than at the floor — shows how different the same film looks on a scale with more than two values, and this desk could read only its citation, not the page.[4]

0% / 99%

CHRISTMAS AT THE KRINGLES FROM 26 CRITICS; LAIKA'S WILDWOOD FROM 156 — BOTH READ ON 31 OCTOBER 2026[1][2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Queens of the Stone Age, *Perfecth*. Out **30 October**. Album of the Year puts the critic score at **80 from 20 reviews** against a user score of **70 from 1,167**. AllMusic hears the crunch reined in; **Paste** is the pan, headlined "Queens of the Stone Age mistake adequate for *Perfecth*". No first-week number exists yet — it cannot chart until next week.[5]

The documentary with legs. You Can See Everything, Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim's A24 film on Elizabeth Holmes, is at **97 per cent from 201** and **$56.9m** after fifteen days, having gone *up* 20.1 per cent in weekend two. The dissent is **Deniz Arslan** at 4 of 10: "What can you get from distilling a single grape for three hours? Only a few drops."[6]

SOURCES 1 Rotten Tomatoes, *Christmas at the Kringles*, read at source 31 October 2026 (26 reviews at the time of reading; the average rating of 3.1/10 is recorded against a count of 24, and the count moved during the day). Critic quotations as carried on that page. 2 Rotten Tomatoes pages for *Wildwood* and *Clayface*, read 31 October 2026; Box Office Mojo daily grosses for 30 October 2026, read at source. **The 30 October to 1 November weekend returned "no data available" on Box Office Mojo; the forecast of a Clayface win is The Numbers', not this desk's.** 3 Roger Friedman, Showbiz411, 31 October 2026, 12:02pm. 4 Metacritic score as cited by the film's Wikipedia entry; **Metacritic itself returned 403 to this desk and the figure is therefore second-hand.** 5 Album of the Year, *Perfecth*, read 31 October 2026; Paste's review. **Metacritic's own 80-from-14 could not be read directly.** 6 Rotten Tomatoes and Box Office Mojo, both read 31 October 2026.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE SCREEN RULES

Screen rules buy back 56 minutes a day, Oregon researchers find

Eight thousand American adolescents, tracked for three years: the strictest parents saw an hour less screen time — and the gap closed by 13 minutes with every year the child aged.

Researchers at Oregon Health & Science University published a study on **28 October** that followed **8,089** American adolescents for three years and asked a question most parents ask in the dark: do the rules actually do anything? The answer is yes, and it is measurable. The children of the strictest households used screens **56 minutes less a day** than the children of the most permissive ones.[1]

Two things make that number worth more than the usual headline. The first is that it was not only asked, it was watched: on the children with Android phones the researchers also read what the phone itself recorded, and the gap there was wider still, **79.3 minutes a day**, and **286 fewer keystrokes**. The second is the age band. The children were around thirteen on average across the window — which is to say, exactly the years a Singapore child enters secondary school.[1]

Then comes the finding nobody puts in the press release. Strictness collapses with age, and it collapses fast. In the first year **46.9 per cent** of parents were in the high-restriction group and **14.4 per cent** in the low. Two years later those had crossed over: **25.3 per cent** high, **36.1 per cent** low. Only **21.5 per cent** of families held the line all three years.[1]

And the gap itself erodes. The researchers put a figure on it: an age interaction of **13 minutes a day**, meaning the strictly-governed children's screen time climbed *faster* each year than everyone else's. Four years of that and the hour you bought is spent. The one lever that stood out in their item-level analysis was not a rule about apps or hours at all, but the bedroom: a screen playing while the child falls asleep was the strongest single predictor of heavy use.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE PARENTS TOLD THE MINISTRY

Singapore has its own dataset on the same question, and it is better than a forum trawl. Between June and August 2026 the Ministry of Digital Development and Information engaged **more than 2,000 parents and young people**, publishing the results on **23 October**. **Over 80 per cent of parents** and **nearly 70 per cent of youth** want tiered, age-based access rather than a ban; close to 80 per cent of parents support age verification. The three safeguards respondents asked for most were disabling autoplay (**76 per cent**), disabling direct messages (**75 per cent**) and a daily time limit (**75 per cent**) — the last of which is precisely the lever the Oregon study measured. The generational split is stark: inappropriate content is the top worry for **84 per cent** of parents and **37 per cent** of youths, while **71 per cent** of youths name overuse.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · AN HOUR A DAY OF WHAT, EXACTLY?

The honest objection to the Oregon finding is that it measures the hour and not the harm. The authors are candid: this is observational, so **reverse causation** is live — parents may relax the rules *because* a child already uses screens lightly — high restriction was commoner in richer, better-educated households, the passive phone data covers Android only, and their bedroom-screen model explained about **ten per cent** of the variance. More importantly, **Amy Orben and Andrew Przybylski** showed across three datasets and **355,358** young people that digital technology use explains **at most 0.4 per cent** of the variation in adolescent well-being, and concluded the effects were "too small to warrant policy change". Buying back an hour is a real result. Whether the hour was doing any damage is a separate question, and this study does not answer it.[3]

21.5%

SHARE OF PARENTS WHO STAYED IN THE HIGH-RESTRICTION GROUP ACROSS ALL THREE YEARS OF THE STUDY. NEARLY FOUR IN FIVE DID NOT[1]

SOURCES 1 Lopez D, Lopez-Flores A, Ruiz-Orozco G, Nagel B, "Longitudinal patterns of digital parenting restrictions and adolescent screen use: insights from the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development study", *PLOS Digital Health* 2026;5(10):e0001127, published 28 October 2026; **full text read at source by this desk.** All effect sizes, group proportions and the authors' own limitations are as stated in the paper. 2 Ministry of Digital Development and Information, "Factsheet: Singapore teens and parents agree: safer social media, not no social media", 23 October 2026, read at source; additional figures from AsiaOne's report of 24 October 2026. **The ministry's own media authority report could not be opened by this desk and nothing is quoted from it.** 3 Orben A, Przybylski AK, "The association between adolescent well-being and digital technology use", *Nature Human Behaviour* 2019;3(2):173–182. **General guidance for parents, not medical advice. Reddit and Mumsnet both refused this desk, so no parent-forum sentiment appears on this page.**

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE SLEEP GAP

Academic Pediatrics finds teenagers report sleep problems their parents miss

United States survey data to December 2023: at four hours a day of screens, teenagers were likelier to have no regular bedtime — and parents consistently under-reported the trouble.

A study in **Academic Pediatrics**, published on **28 October**, compared two accounts of the same children's sleep: what teenagers said about themselves, and what their parents said about them. The two did not match. Parents reported fewer sleep problems than their own teenagers reported, across a national American sample collected between July 2021 and December 2023.[1]

That matters because almost everything a household does about sleep — the bedtime, the device rule, the decision to worry — runs on the parent's reading. If the reading is systematically rosier than the child's, the rule is set against the wrong picture. The study also found a clean dose pattern: teenagers reporting two hours or less of daily screen time, three hours, and four or more reported progressively worse sleep, and the heaviest group was likeliest to have no fixed bedtime at all.[1]

Singapore has already legislated around the first of those two findings and not the second. From **January 2026** the Ministry of Education widened its rules on secondary-school phones and smartwatches from lesson time to the whole school day — recess, co-curricular activities, remedial lessons — with devices kept in lockers or bags, and parents needing urgent contact going through the general office. In the same month the default sleep-hour cut-off on school-issued learning devices moved earlier, from **11.00pm to 10.30pm**.[2]

What is coming is bigger. The Government has said it intends to introduce legislation next year — **2027** — covering mandatory age assurance and safer-by-design requirements for teenagers, including restrictions on unwanted contact, on autoplay, and on daily time limits. A twelve-year-old starting secondary school now will be fifteen when that regime is fully upon her.[3]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE TEENAGERS ON SLEEP AND ACCESS

Teenagers are not only the ones reporting the sleep problems in **Academic Pediatrics**; they are also the ones with a view on the screens. Asked by the Ministry of Digital Development and Information where age-appropriate access should end, Singapore's young people drew the line later than the loudest public argument assumes. They placed **ages 7–12 and 13–15 at age-appropriate access** — the same as their parents — and backed greater freedom from about **sixteen**. The split came at 16–17: youths divided between full and age-appropriate access, parents not. Some warned strict limits get in the way of schoolwork. **The factsheet attaches no percentage to the age-sixteen finding**, so this desk prints none.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · THE SLEEP STUDY PUBLISHES NO EFFECT SIZE

Take the **Academic Pediatrics** parent-and-teenager sleep gap seriously, but carefully. The published abstract gives **no sample size and no effect size**, so the scale of the discrepancy is unknown to anyone who has not read the full paper — this desk has not, and prints no figure. The two halves also come from different instruments and years: the teenagers from a 2021–23 adolescent survey, the parents from the 2022 interview survey. A parent and a child answering different questionnaires in different years will differ for reasons unrelated to insight. And this is American data; Singapore's school start times and tuition load are not America's.[4]

10.30pm

THE DEFAULT SLEEP-HOUR CUT-OFF ON SINGAPORE SCHOOL LEARNING DEVICES SINCE JANUARY 2026, MOVED EARLIER BY HALF AN HOUR[2]

SOURCES 1 Zablotsky B, Black LI, Ng AE, Bose J, Jones JR, Blumberg SJ, "Parent- and teen-reported prevalence of sleep health and habits and teen-reported associations with screen time", *Academic Pediatrics*, electronic publication 28 October 2026. **Abstract only; the full paper was not read by this desk, and no sample size or effect size is published in the abstract.** 2 Ministry of Education press release of 30 November 2025 and the parliamentary replies of 13 and 14 January 2026. **The ministry's pages render empty to this desk; the policy is reported from their indexed text and is a ten-month-old standing rule, not news.** 3 Ministry of Digital Development and Information factsheet, 23 October 2026, read at source. 4 The limitations are as stated, or as absent, in the published abstract. 5 Garcia-Casal MN, Pardo-Hernandez H, "Synopsis of the World Health Organization guidelines on childhood and adolescent obesity management", *Clinical and Public Health Guidelines* 2026;3(4):e70094, 27 October 2026. **General guidance for parents, not medical advice.**

THE MACRO DESK · GOLD AND THE REAL YIELD

Gold falls to a one-year low as Treasury real yields drop

Spot gold closed 30 October at $3,874, down 3.6 per cent in a day — while the United States Treasury's ten-year real yield fell 28 basis points across the month.

Gold had its worst day since the summer on Friday **30 October**, closing around **$3,874** an ounce on Kitco's and Reuters' readings, its lowest since early October 2025. Silver fell about six per cent on the day and nine on the week. That happened in a month when the single number most often used to explain the gold price — what a saver gives up by holding metal instead of a government bond — moved steadily in gold's favour.[1]

Here is the idea in plain terms. Gold pays no interest. So the usual argument is that when the inflation-adjusted return on a safe bond falls, gold should rise, because the cost of owning something that pays nothing has gone down. The United States Treasury publishes that inflation-adjusted return every day. On 1 October the ten-year figure was **2.88 per cent**. On 30 October it was **2.60 per cent** — twenty-eight basis points cheaper to hold gold, and gold fell anyway.[2]

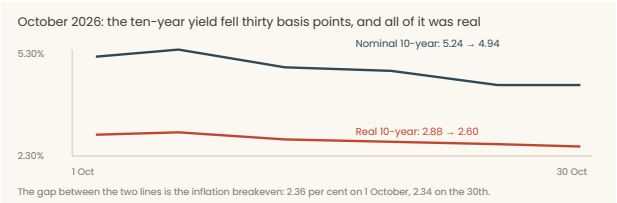
The rest of the curve says the same thing happened for an unusual reason. The nominal ten-year note went from **5.24 per cent** to **4.94**, a thirty-basis-point fall. Subtract the real yield from the nominal and you get what the market expects inflation to average: **2.36 per cent** on 1 October, **2.34** on 30 October. Essentially unchanged.[2]

What actually drove the week was equity de-positioning in the artificial-intelligence complex. **Alphabet** fell **12.6 per cent** on 29 October, its worst day ever, shedding about half a trillion dollars; **Intel** fell **29 per cent** on the 30th, its worst since the 1970s. The S&P 500 closed at **7,580.07**, a third straight weekly fall. Bitcoin, which trades as a liquidity proxy rather than a haven, fell with them to **$77,223**, touching a six-week low of $76,368.[3]

THE FOUR ANCHORS · FRIDAY 30 OCTOBER CLOSE

VWRA[4]	$188.54	▼ 1.43%
AGGU (global agg)[4]	$5.802	▲ 0.16%
Gold spot[1]	$3,874	▼ 3.6%
Bitcoin[3]	$77,223	▼ 4.2%
US 10y real[2]	2.60%	▼ 3bp

Market explanation, not investment advice. Levels as published by the issuers and the Treasury; the breakeven and curve figures are this desk's own arithmetic.[2]



Meridian original, plotted from the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves for October 2026. Intermediate points are the published series; the breakeven is this desk's arithmetic.

2 bp

THE MOVE IN THE TEN-YEAR INFLATION BREAKEVEN ACROSS OCTOBER. THE NOMINAL YIELD FELL 30 BASIS POINTS; ESSENTIALLY ALL OF IT WAS THE REAL YIELD[2]

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE FOUR

Equities: a de-rating of one sector, not an earnings break — Alphabet's revenue grew 25 per cent and its margin expanded. **Global bonds:** diversifying as intended, with a 4.30 per cent yield to maturity underneath them.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · THE HIKE IS NOT PRICED IN YET

The consensus says December brings a hike. Two things say the market has not accepted it. The **Federal Open Market Committee** held on **28 October** with **Lisa Cook** and **Beth Hammack** both dissenting for a quarter-point rise — the first time since **1992** that a governor and a reserve-bank president dissented together in the same direction.[6]

SOURCES 1 Gold and silver spot closes for 30 October 2026 as published by Kitco and by Reuters, two independent readings, consistent at $3,880 and $3,874.58; the COMEX December contract settled at $3,898.90, down 3.29 per cent. **The LBMA's own price file refused this desk, so no fix is quoted.** 2 United States Treasury, Daily Treasury Par Yield Curve Rates and Daily Treasury Par Real Yield Curve Rates for October 2026, both read at source by this desk. **The breakeven and the 2s10s spread are this magazine's own arithmetic on those two published series.** 3 Alphabet and Intel moves as reported by NBC News, 29 October 2026, and CNBC, 30 October 2026; index closes and the volatility index from the daily series; bitcoin from CoinGecko's daily series, with the six-week intraday low as logged by Reuters. 4 Vanguard's and iShares' own issuer pages for VWRA and AGGU, as at 30 October 2026; AGGU's weighted average yield to maturity of 4.30 per cent is as at 29 October. 5 Alphabet's own Q3 2026 results exhibit, filed 28 October 2026, read at source. 6 Federal Open Market Committee statement of 28 October 2026 and the recorded dissents. **This desk explains markets; it does not give investment advice, and no figure here is a recommendation.**

THE RABBIT HOLE · IKEBANA

Ikebana lost three-quarters of Japan's practitioners in thirty-five years

The Statistics Bureau counted 6.04 million in 1986 and 1.39 million in 2021 — and among 25- to 29-year-olds the participation rate fell from 9.2 per cent to 0.4.

Ikebana is not flower arranging as the West does it. Western arranging fills a volume: mass, colour, symmetry, a dome of blooms. Ikebana builds a *line* in space, deliberately lopsided, and treats the empty air around the stems as part of the work. Three principal stems set up a triangle of unequal lengths and everything else is subordinate to them. The oldest school names those three **shin**, **soe** and **tai** — truth, support, body; another calls them heaven, man and earth.[1]

The second thing an outsider needs is stranger, and it is the reason people stay. The material is treated as having a will of its own, which the arranger is obliged to obey. **Suidô Yamane**, who founded his own school in 1927, put it without softening: "If you bring flower materials together forcibly against nature's will, ignoring the expression of each flower and the wishes of each flower material, the flowers, leaves and branches of the work are complaining. They look sad, lacking vitality… Unhealthy ikebana is not 'ikebana (living flowers)' but dead flowers."[2]

And it is collapsing. Japan's Statistics Bureau counts participants in its national time-use survey: **6,040,000** in 1986, **4,556,000** in 1996, **2,041,000** in 2016, **1,390,000** in 2021. As a share of everyone over fifteen, that is **6.4 per cent down to 1.3**. The art critic **Mitôya Takashi**, who assembled the series, found the sharpest cut among people aged **25 to 29**: from **9.2 per cent in 1986 to 0.4 per cent in 2021**, a factor of twenty-three. One journalist's estimate puts the 1966 figure at ten million.[3]

It is also, overwhelmingly, something women do. The 2016 survey counted **1,899,000 women against 139,000 men** — a male share of **6.8 per cent**. That single number explains a great deal of what follows, including why the oldest school in Japan now runs a boy band.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHY IKENOBO INVENTED IKENOBOYS

Ikenobo, the Kyoto school whose records go back to **1462**, produces an all-male group called **IKENOBOYS** — a pun on *ikemen*, good-looking men — whose named members hold the rank of *junkyô* or above: **Kamisai Shôgo**, **Teshima Yûto**, **Tanaka Nobuaki**. The scholar **Imai Takashi**, writing in the peer-reviewed *International Journal of Ikebana Studies*, records the reason the school gave itself: a sense of crisis that "we can't go on targeting women only". His assessment of the result is cooler — their output is "centred on advocacy rather than instruction in arranging technique".[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE IKEBANA SCHOOLS ADMIT

Imai's opening line in print is not a critic's: "The ikebana population continues to decline. In particular, the decline has been unstoppable for 20 years since 1996." He is blunt that the schools tried — "each school, carrying a continuing sense of crisis… must have taken all sorts of measures aimed at women… Nevertheless the ikebana population has collapsed" — and he names three causes from his own earlier work: Japanese houses no longer have the alcove the art was designed for, women's lives diversified, and the hereditary school system is *futoômei*, opaque.[5]

23×

THE FALL IN PARTICIPATION AMONG JAPANESE AGED 25 TO 29 BETWEEN 1986 AND 2021, FROM 9.2 PER CENT TO 0.4[3]

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

The gear, from a ¥2,772 pair of shears to a ¥86,740 pair that weighs exactly the same; the pin frog, the bronze vessel and the signed box.

The certificate economy — one school publishes its whole ladder, and it comes to ¥318,000 before the customary cash gratuity that can double every step.

SOURCES 1 Ikenobo's and Ohara's own English pages on shôka and moribana; the Ikebana International school profile for Misho-ryû's heaven-man-earth naming. 2 Suidô Yamane, *Hana ni ikiru hitotachi he* (1967), translated by Shoso Shimbo in the *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* Vol. 9 (2022), pp. 76–78, read at source on J-STAGE. 3 Statistics Bureau of Japan, Survey on Time Use and Leisure Activities; the 1986–2021 series and the 25–29 figure as compiled by Mitôya Takashi, professor emeritus of Nagoya Zokei University, 5 August 2023 (he corrected the factor from 25 to 23 on 21 August). The ten-million estimate for 1966 is journalist Aochi Shin's, as cited by Mitôya. 4 Imai Takashi, "A tentative plan for expanding the ikebana population", *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* Vol. 9 (2022), pp. 37–53; IKENOBOYS members from the group's own site. 5 Imai, op. cit.; Yuko Tsuboi, "Ikebana practice and transmission in contemporary society", *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* Vol. 13 (2026), pp. 38–71, released 3 April 2026.

The whole tool kit costs less than a decent chef's knife, and the ladder above it runs a hundred times further. Ohara's own shop sells its entry shears, the **Wakaba**, at **¥2,772**; a round pin frog from **¥740**; and — the purchase that tells you what sort of objects these are — a **¥660** steel tool whose only job is straightening bent pins. Total **¥4,172**: a complete working kit.[1]

Now the other end. At **Kanetaka Hamono Shinise**, a Kyoto blade shop founded long before any of this, the top of the range is the **Rakuun** at **¥86,740**. It is 175mm overall with a 60mm blade and it weighs **145 grams**. The shop's own mid-range *shirauchi* pair, at **¥13,040**, is 165mm with a 60mm blade and weighs **145 grams**. Same form, same mass, same cutting job, six and a half times the money.[2]

What you buy is steel, forging and finish, in that order. The good blades are Yasugi carbon steel — *shirogami*, white paper, keenest and least forgiving, or *aogami*, blue paper, alloyed to hold an edge — laminated to soft iron and hand-forged, against stamped stainless at the bottom. Kanetaka's ladder is then purely a finish ladder on one form: *kurouchi*, as-forged, **¥6,880**; half-polished, **¥7,430**; *shirauchi*, **¥12,930–16,560**; fully polished, **¥20,960**. Three times the price for hand-work on identical geometry.[2]

The vessel is cheaper than you would guess. A *suiban*, the shallow basin the modern style was invented for in 1895, is about **US$104** for a 12-inch round from Arakawa Pottery in San Jose. A genuine Meiji bronze **usubata** — the trumpet-mouthed vessel of the classical tradition — sits at **€700 to €1,000** with European dealers. The expensive tier is contemporary studio ceramic: a Bizen *hanaire* by **Kakurezaki Ryûichi**, whose work is in the V&A, at **¥394,000** in Kyoto; a Bizen *kaki* by **Kaneshige Kôsuke** at **¥242,000**. The signed box is part of the price.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT IKEBANA STUDENTS ARGUE ABOUT

The liveliest argument in ikebana is whether it can be taught at a distance, and it is being had in print rather than on a forum. **Shoso Shimbo**, who studied under the late Sôgetsu headmaster and teaches in Melbourne, states the obstacle structurally: "Remote learning is in principle incompatible with the traditional iemoto system which is based on face to face interaction... It is therefore difficult or even prohibited in some cases." He adds that the schools have kept curriculum development "exclusively" in-house and out of academic scrutiny — so the claim that only a teacher can teach you has never been tested. The gate is already ajar: **Ichiyô** runs a correspondence programme, and **Ilse Beunen** in Antwerp sells self-guided courses with Sôgetsu certification.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · ABOVE THE MID TIER YOU ARE COLLECTING

The case against the expensive shears is in the shop's own catalogue. The **¥13,040** pair and the **¥86,740** pair are both five *sun* five *bu*, both 60mm of blade, both **145g**. The gain above the middle is edge retention and feel, not capability, on a tool whose job is cutting soft stems — and a **¥660** pin-straightener plus a sharpening service keeps the cheap kit alive indefinitely. Buy-once-cry-once here means the **¥13,000–18,000** band. Above it you are collecting, which is fine as long as you know you are.[2]

¥95–101

AVERAGE JAPANESE CUT-FLOWER PRICE PER STEM AT 2026'S PEAKS, AGAINST A REFERENCE LINE OF ¥61 — THE FLOWERS, NOT THE TOOLS, ARE THE REAL COST[5]

THE GLOSSARY

kadô — 華道 the way of flowers. **rikka — 立華** the oldest upright style, out of Buddhist altar offerings. **shôka — 生花** the three-stem classical form. **moribana — 盛花** "piled-up flowers", invented 1895 for the shallow basin.

nageire — 投入 "thrown in": the tall vase, stems held by geometry not pins. **jiyûka — 自由花** free style, which the school says has "no fixed rules or forms". **ma — 間** the charged interval; the empty part doing the work.

kenzan — 剣山 "sword mountain", the pinned frog. **shippô — 七宝** the ring holder used instead. **tomegi — 留め木** twigs wedged in a vase mouth. **tomobako — 共箱** the maker's signed box, part of a vessel's value.

SOURCES 1 Hanamore, the official Ohara-ryû online store, read at source 31 October 2026. 2 Kanetaka Hamono Shinise, Kyoto, product listings read at source 31 October 2026; weights and blade lengths as the shop publishes them. **The Rakuun page renders with a character-encoding fault, so its steel specification is not printed here.** 3 Arakawa Pottery, San Jose; Meiji usubata listings at Galerie Raoul Dutillieul and Galerie la Belle Époque via Proantic; Kura Monzen Gallery and Bizen Gallery Aoyama, Kyoto — all read at source 31 October 2026. 4 Shoso Shimbo, "A proposal for online ikebana training", *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* Vol. 9 (2022), pp. 19–36; Ichiyô's correspondence programme per the Ikebana International school profile; ikebana.be. 5 Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Fisheries, 「花きの現状について」, June 2026 edition, price-trend section, data to 31 May 2026; **the PDF was downloaded and text-extracted by this desk. Instagram and YouTube both refused this desk, so no follower or subscriber count appears anywhere in this desk.**

The tools are cheap and the rank is not. Ikebana's schools run on licences — you apply through your own teacher, you cannot skip a step, and each promotion costs money. Most schools keep the figures private. **Ryûsei-ha** does not, and its published ladder is the clearest window anyone has into what the certificate economy actually charges.[1]

Its fees run **¥10,000** at the first rank, then **¥18,000**, **¥25,000**, **¥35,000**, **¥45,000**, **¥50,000**, **¥60,000** and **¥75,000**. Run the whole ladder and the licences alone come to **¥318,000** — this desk's addition of the school's own figures — on top of **¥6,000** to enrol, **¥5,000–8,000** a month in tuition and **¥1,500–6,000** a session in flowers.[1]

Then the part on no price list. Japanese guidance on **Ikenobo** custom records that the thank-you to your teacher is *customarily the same amount as the application fee*, in cash; that some teachers fold it in and some decline it; and that if unsure, you ask the senior students, not the teacher. Each promotion can cost twice its sticker price. Ikenobo publishes no fees at all. **Sôgetsu**, asked about honoraria on its own questions page, answers in five words: the school "does not recommend it".[2]

Which makes Singapore the cheapest serious ikebana tuition this desk could find anywhere. At **Siglap South Community Club**, eight Monday evenings to 23 November cost **S$93 to S$104** plus **S$8–20** of materials paid to the trainer, **Tan Hwee Hia**, of the Sôgetsu school — about **S$12 a lesson**, against C$50 in Halifax. An Ikenobo beginner course at **Tiong Bahru** is **S$300–360** for six, flowers to take home, vases and pin frogs lent.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT SINGAPORE ARRANGERS PUT IN THE VASE

The awkwardness of ikebana in Singapore is that the art is built on a seasonal calendar the island does not have. Local practice borrows the idea of a season and fills it with the tropics: the Japan Creative Centre's chapter shows have run as *Autumn Sonata*, *Autumn Breeze* and, in 2025, *Autumn Whisper*, while a 2015 exhibition used **orchids, ginger and heliconias** preserved by the Botanic Gardens.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE LICENCE ACTUALLY BUYS

Pressed on what the money buys, the trade's answer is modest: accreditation lets you resume where you stopped with a different teacher, and returning students must show their certificates to re-enter at level. That is portability, not skill. Against it sit **¥318,000** of published fees, about **¥100,000** for the board that marks you as licensed to teach, and a gratuity that can double each step. **Imai Takashi** calls the system *futoômei* — opaque — in a peer-reviewed journal, and records why the ranks were once worth buying: a licence helped a daughter marry above her parents' class.[5]

S$12

COST OF ONE IKEBANA LESSON AT A SINGAPORE COMMUNITY CLUB, AGAINST C$50 IN HALIFAX AND ¥5,000–8,000 A MONTH IN JAPAN[3]

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Days 1–14, spend nothing. The *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* is free on J-STAGE; Sôgetsu's curriculum pages are public. Go to a show.

Days 31–90, buy three things: shears, a heavy round pin frog, the ¥660 straightener — **¥4,172** entry, **¥9,740** at Kanetaka's — then one basin, about **US$104**.

NEXT DESCENTS

Shodō (Japanese calligraphy) — the other brush art with a licence ladder, an ink-stone grail tier and a live argument about whether the grades mean anything.

Rug tufting — a four-year-old hobby built on one power tool, a cloth frame and a YouTube economy, with a second-hand market nobody has mapped.

Sashiko & boro mending — running-stitch repair as a discipline: indigo cloth, needle gauges, and a provenance market in genuinely worn-out textiles.

SOURCES 1 Ryûsei-ha's own beginners' guide, read at source 31 October 2026, which publishes enrolment, monthly tuition, per-session material costs and the full certificate schedule. **The ¥318,000 total is this magazine's own addition of the school's eight published application fees.** 2 Wagokoro's guide to kadô accomplishments, updated 27 June 2024, on Ikenobo custom; Ikenobo's own pages, which defer fees to the instructor; the Sôgetsu School frequently-asked-questions page, read at source. **Ikenobo's figures are reported ranges, not published prices, and are printed as such.** 3 People's Association course listings for Siglap South Community Club (ref C027236932) and Tiong Bahru Community Club (ref C027240604), both read at source 31 October 2026; the Halifax comparison from The Ikebana Shop's own lesson page. 4 Japan Creative Centre exhibition titles and the 2015 and 2024 details **reached only through the search index — the embassy's own pages returned 403 to this desk**; prices from Far East Flora Market's own listings, read 31 October 2026. 5 The Ikebana Shop's lesson questions page on what accreditation does; Imai Takashi, *International Journal of Ikebana Studies* Vol. 9 (2022); Yuko Tsuboi, ibid. Vol. 13 (2026), pp. 38–71.

FITNESS · THE ACHILLES INJECTION

A Melbourne trial finds Achilles injections no better than a sham

The Inject trial put 192 adults of average age 49 into three arms for twelve months: the steroid group led at six weeks, trailed by six months, and was level at a year.

A randomised trial published in the British Medical Journal on **28 October** tested the injection most commonly offered for a painful Achilles tendon, and found it did nothing that a dummy injection did not also do. **192** adults took part, average age **49**, with symptoms of about two years' standing. At twelve months, with **94 per cent** still being followed, no arm was meaningfully better than any other.[1]

The design is what makes it useful to anyone in their forties with a grumbling heel. All three groups got the same thing first: a progressive loading programme, education and advice on modifying activity. On top of that one group got a dummy injection of local anaesthetic, one a large-volume saline injection, and one the same volume with **25mg** of hydrocortisone in it. The exercise was the constant; the needle was the variable. At twelve months the differences on the standard tendon score all straddled zero, and average scores rose from **48.7** at baseline in every arm.[1]

The trade is in the timing, and it is the headline. At **six weeks** the steroid group was genuinely ahead of the sham, by **9.2 points**. By **26 weeks** it had fallen **8.6 points** behind the saline group. The shot buys six weeks and repays it by six months. A health-economic analysis gave the steroid arm a better than nine-in-ten chance of being cost-effective at the usual thresholds — and the authors still decline to support routine use.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE ARGUMENT RAN INSIDE THE JOURNAL

The debate about this trial was published alongside it rather than left to the forums. **John Orchard** of the University of Sydney wrote the linked editorial the same day, **28 October**: "All clinicians recommending or performing corticosteroid injections for tendinopathy need to understand this trade-off." His position is neither dismissal nor endorsement — inject only where a short-term need genuinely dominates a long-term one, and never tell a patient it will cure the tendon. He has standing: he co-authored the 2011 review finding the same short-good, long-bad pattern in tennis elbow, fifteen years before this trial reproduced it in the Achilles. **Reddit and the trial's expert-reaction page both refused this desk.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE ACHILLES TRIAL CANNOT SETTLE

The authors' own weaknesses are real: recruitment largely through social media, which is not a clinic population; injectors who could not be blinded to what they were giving; and enough comparisons that some differences may be chance. There is a harder objection. A trial in which every arm gets the active treatment cannot say the injection is useless — only that it adds nothing to loading.[3]

+9.2 / −8.6

THE STEROID ARM'S LEAD OVER THE SHAM AT SIX WEEKS, AND ITS DEFICIT AGAINST PLAIN SALINE AT TWENTY-SIX — THE WHOLE TRADE IN TWO NUMBERS[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Evening training does not wreck your sleep. A cross-over trial in *Sleep Medicine* gave adults aged 60–80 with insomnia fourteen days of coached morning activity and fourteen of evening, and found **no difference** in insomnia severity. Only the sleep midpoint moved, by a third of a minute. **Thirty-one** participants, and the wrong age band — but the timing anxiety a recovery ring encourages is unsupported here.[4]

SOURCES 1 Malliaras P, Connell D, Boesen AP, Kearney RS, Menz HB, Morrissey D, Munteanu SE, Silbernagel KG, Underwood M, Forbes A, Haines TP, "Efficacy and cost effectiveness of high volume injections with and without corticosteroid compared with sham for midportion Achilles tendinopathy (Inject trial): randomised controlled trial", *BMJ* 2026;395:e100807, published 28 October 2026; trial registration ACTRN12619001455156. 2 John Orchard, "Corticosteroid injections to treat tendinopathy", linked *BMJ* editorial, 28 October 2026; the quotation is as carried by News-Medical on the same day. **bmj.com returned 403 to this desk, so the editorial body itself is unread and only the dated, attributed quotation is printed.** 3 Limitations as stated by the trial authors. 4 Albalak G and colleagues, "The effect of physical activity timing on insomnia and sleep quality: a randomized cross-over trial in older adults", *Sleep Medicine* 2026;149:109332, 23 October 2026. **The abstract's stated direction of the sleep-midpoint shift is internally inconsistent with the times it gives, so no direction is printed.** 5 Huang G and colleagues, "Dose-response effects of exercise training on circulating brain-derived neurotrophic factor", *Molecular Neurobiology* 2026;63(1):993, 26 October 2026. **This desk prints general guidance, not medical advice.**

DEPARTURES · THE DUBAI SUSPENSION

Singapore Airlines pushes its Dubai restart to March 2027, a fourth delay

SQ494 and SQ495 are now cancelled through 28 February, making a full year without a Singapore–Dubai flight — and the A380 freed by it has gone to Auckland instead.

Singapore Airlines has cancelled its Dubai flights for another three months. The route, suspended since **28 February 2026** over what the airline calls the geopolitical situation in the Middle East, will now not resume until **1 March 2027** — an **89-day** extension that makes a full calendar year with no direct service between the two cities.[1]

This is the fourth time the restart has moved. It was first set for **29 March 2026**, then pushed to **2 December 2026** as recently as 1 October, and now to March. Several wire reports are still carrying "Dubai returns 24 October 2026"; that is wrong. When it does come back it will be a two-class A350 for the first month, switching to a four-class Boeing 777-300ER with four First seats from **28 March 2027**, and filings keep that aircraft on the route through the following winter — so no A380 to Dubai before 2028.[1]

The aeroplane has gone somewhere better. From **25 October** Singapore Airlines put the A380 on Auckland year-round for the first time, including through the New Zealand winter. Against the 777-300ER it replaces, that is Suites **4 to 6**, Business **48 to 78**, Premium Economy **28 to 44** and Economy **184 to 343** — **264 seats to 471**, a 78 per cent increase on every rotation. Christchurch gets the four-class 777 from **1 May 2027**, which returns First Class to the South Island.[2]

Elsewhere in the winter changeover that began on 25 October: Singapore Airlines flies to **Madrid** again after twenty-two years, five times a week via Barcelona on **SQ387/388**; Changi's new destinations for the year include Chiang Rai, Dalian, Pontianak, Belitung, Newcastle and the Sunshine Coast; and **Turkish Airlines** began routing Sydney–Istanbul through Changi with local pick-up rights.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE A350 RETROFIT LEAVES OUT

Singapore Airlines will rebuild **41 aircraft** — 34 long-haul A350-900s and 7 ultra-long-range — at a programme cost of about **S$1.1bn**, first aircraft in service **Q1 2027**. Business gets a **22-inch 4K** screen, Bluetooth, USB-C and wireless charging; First, on the four ultra-long-range seats, gets **32 inches** and wireless headphones. Premium Economy and Economy get new software and, in the airline's own word, will be "refreshed". No 4K, no Bluetooth, no USB-C; Economy keeps wired earphones. The 777-9 gets all of it in every cabin. In the One Mile at a Time thread, **Mike O.** (5 May) called the design "status quo… nothing revolutionary"; **yoloswag420** (1 September) wrote that "hard product is plateauing across the board" and that Singapore Airlines "otherwise has a very average hard product in business class". Tellingly, nobody in that thread is complaining about Economy at all.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · CHANGI'S GROWTH CASE AND A FLAT QUARTER

Changi Airport Group used Routes World on **23 October** to set out the money: **S$3bn** into the *existing* terminals — Terminal 3, baggage handling, the Skytrain — with Terminal 5 still mid-2030s, when it will add **50 million** passengers a year and take the airport from about 90 million to 140. The pitch rests on Asia-Pacific traffic growing 5 to 6 per cent a year. Changi's own third quarter grew **0.4 per cent**, to 17.4 million. The airport's executive was candid about why: on growth plans, he said, "people are being careful… But there are other airlines that want to pursue growth." A fourteen-year building programme underwritten by a thesis the current quarter does not support is a risk worth naming.[5]

+78%

THE SEAT INCREASE ON SINGAPORE–AUCKLAND WHEN THE A380 REPLACES THE 777-300ER, FROM 264 SEATS TO 471[2]

SOURCES 1 Singapore Airlines travel advisory "Flights affected by the geopolitical situation in the Middle East", updated 30 October 2026, as cited and schedule-read by Mainly Miles, 31 October 2026. **singaporeair.com returned 404 on every advisory URL this desk tried, so the advisory is cited at one remove.** 2 Mainly Miles, 27 October 2026, from published schedules; KrisFlyer award levels read at source 31 October 2026. 3 Embassy of Spain in Singapore, 8 May 2026, on the Madrid service; Lim Ching Kiat of Changi Airport Group at Routes World 2026, reported by Aviation Week, 23 October 2026. **The Turkish Airlines routing and the Gatwick, Milan and Munich frequency changes are secondary and unverified at primary source.** 4 MileLion, 22 and 25 October 2026, on the retrofit; comments read at source in the One Mile at a Time community thread, 31 October 2026, handles and dates as published. **FlyerTalk returned 403 to this desk and nothing is attributed to it.** 5 Aviation Week, 23 October 2026; Changi traffic figures as reported there.

DEPARTURES · THE JOHOR RAIL LINK

Anthony Loke says the Johor rail link opens in February and is not delayed

The operator moved the date on 2 October; Malaysia's transport minister says construction finishes 31 December and February is a deliberate buffer. No day has been fixed.

The shuttle railway between Johor Bahru and Woodlands has a month but still no date. On **2 October** the operating company said passenger service was "currently estimated to start in February 2027", allowing for third-party safety certification and approvals from both governments. Six days later Malaysia's transport minister **Anthony Loke** rejected the word delay: "It is not delayed. The project's physical construction will be completed on Dec 31... We agreed that the best decision is to start the service in February 2027... We do not want to take the risk of rushing the opening."[1]

Loke said trains could technically run in January and that February is a buffer. The honest state of play: the day comes only once both regulators sign off, and **Singapore has published nothing** — its land transport authority's newsroom carries no release on the link since January 2021. Fares are unset; a February 2026 Malaysian estimate of five to seven Singapore dollars has never been confirmed.[1]

The specification is settled even if the date is not: two stations, each with both countries' checkpoints under one roof, a journey of about **five minutes**, a peak gap of **3.6 minutes** between trains, eight driverless four-car sets built by CRRC Zhuzhou carrying more than **600** passengers each, capacity of **10,000** an hour in one direction and a projected **40,000** riders a day. The existing Tebrau shuttle train stops within six months of launch.[2]

The other thing to know before a November trip is that Japan changes its tax-free shopping rules **today**. From **1 November 2026** you pay the full tax-inclusive price in the shop and claim the refund at the airport instead of at the till.[3]

THE CHATTER · JAPAN'S NEW TAX-FREE RECEIPT TRAP

The good news first. The minimum is unchanged at **¥5,000** before tax in one shop on one day; the split between consumables and general goods is **abolished**, taking with it the **¥500,000** cap and the sealed-bag rule; the purchase window is harmonised at **90 days**. The trap is new: **if several items share one receipt, every one must be with you at departure** — one missing item voids the refund on the whole purchase. The departure step is mandatory now, at a customs terminal or through Visit Japan Web before check-in; green means go, red means inspection. Separately the departure tax rises from **¥1,000 to ¥3,000**, confirmed in the finance ministry's own reform document, which gives no effective date.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A LOUNGE OPENED WITHOUT ITS LAVATORIES

Singapore Airlines soft-opened the rebuilt **KrisFlyer Gold Lounge** at Changi Terminal 2 by **26 October**: timber partitions, a live laksa station, part of a **S$45m** rebuild adding half again as much seating. What is not in it is the showers and the lavatories, still a building site, completing **mid-2027**. The old lounge had neither; the nearest were outside in a corridor.[4]

¥53,000

THE SEVEN-DAY JAPAN RAIL PASS FROM 1 OCTOBER 2026, UP FROM ¥50,000; BOOKINGS THROUGH THE OFFICIAL SITE CAN STILL REACH PRE-OCTOBER PRICES FOR AN UNANNOUNCED PERIOD[5]

IN BRIEF

Ski country. Mercure Niseko Resort opens at East Hirafu this month, converting the former Midtown Niseko, with a free winter shuttle to Hirafu. Accor publishes no rate. Fairmont Niseko is **2028**.[6]

SOURCES 1 RTS Operations Pte Ltd statement of 2 October 2026 as reported by Channel NewsAsia the same day — **CNA is unreachable from this desk and the quotation is carried at one remove**; Anthony Loke's remarks read at source in Free Malaysia Today and The Star, both 8 October 2026; Singapore's Land Transport Authority newsroom read in full 31 October 2026, carrying no release on the link since 29 January 2021. 2 Ministry of Transport press release of 30 June 2025, read at source. 3 Japan's tax-free changes per japan-guide.com's summary page dated 26 June 2026; the departure-tax rise from the Ministry of Finance's own "FY2026 Tax Reform (Proposals)", provisional English translation, **downloaded and text-extracted by this desk. The commonly cited 1 July 2026 effective date for the tax rise is not in the ministry document and is not printed as fact.** 4 MileLion, 27 October 2026, on the Terminal 2 lounge; Mainly Miles, 27 October 2026, on the Qantas and Qatar changes. **The S$45m and the 50 per cent seating figures are MileLion's; Singapore Airlines' own release was unreachable.** 5 Japan National Tourism Organization's own announcement of the 1 October 2026 rail-pass increase, read at source. 6 Accor's own hotel page, read 31 October 2026, which publishes no rate.

THE GRAND TOUR · NEPAL

Ratnapark data show Kathmandu's air 72 per cent dirtier in November

A three-year series from the Ratnapark station puts Kathmandu at 39.3 micrograms of fine particulate in October and 67.4 in November — within 3 per cent of January, its filthiest month.

Every guide to Nepal says the same thing: go in October or November. The mountains are out, the monsoon has washed the sky, the trails are dry. That advice is right about the mountains and wrong about the city, and the gap between the two is one month wide. A monitoring station at **Ratnapark**, in the middle of Kathmandu, has been measuring the air for years, and the numbers run the opposite way to the trekking calendar.[1]

Here is what it recorded, averaged across 2020 to 2022, in micrograms of the finest smoke particles per cubic metre of air — the stuff small enough to reach the bloodstream. October: **39.3**, the cleanest month outside the monsoon. November: **67.4**. December: **71.7**. January: **69.5**. November, in other words, is within three per cent of the city's dirtiest month, and the jump from October is **72 per cent**. As the mountains come out, the valley fills up.[1]

The mechanism is an inversion: cold air settles in the bowl the valley sits in and holds the smoke down. The same dataset quantifies the other trap travellers walk into. **April** reads 65.4 for fine particulate and **227** for total suspended particles, the year's worst coarse-dust month, and the paper attributes the March-April spike to "a surge in forest fires across the country". There is a real improvement underneath all this — the annual mean fell from **50.2** in 2020 to **35.2** in 2022 — but the shape of the year has not changed.[1]

So the genuine sweet spot for a trip that includes city days is the **last week of October and the first of November**, which is now. And it happens to coincide with the best week in the Nepali year: **Tihar** runs **7 to 11 November 2026**, with **Laxmi Puja**, the night the houses are lit, on Sunday **8 November**, and **Mha Puja**, the Newar new year, on Tuesday the **10th** — the single most atmospheric date in the calendar for anyone based in Patan or Bhaktapur, and one almost no English guide flags.[2]

GETTING THERE · SINGAPORE TO KATHMANDU DIRECT

Contrary to a good deal of received wisdom, **Singapore Airlines flies Changi to Kathmandu non-stop**, in about **five hours**, on 737 MAX 8 and 787 equipment — confirmed in a schedule database read at source, though the airline's own destination pages would not yield a route listing to this desk. One-stop alternatives are deep: four carriers on Kuala Lumpur, four on Delhi, Thai through Bangkok, Qatar through Doha. **Air India**'s own site quotes from **S$310**; a realistic peak-season return sits around **S$600–900** one-stop. Tribhuvan has **one runway and no instrument landing system**, approaches by satellite and beacon, and an international apron that fits seventeen aircraft, three of them wide-body — which is why delays propagate. For Pokhara the honest answer is that it has exactly **one** scheduled international flight, flydubai's daily from Dubai since **23 September 2026**; Bhairahawa has none.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A GUIDE RULE NEPAL HAS NOT PUBLISHED

Independent trekkers are told a licensed guide is compulsory in the national parks. The strongest source for it is not Nepali: the **United Kingdom's** foreign office, current at 31 October, states foreign independent trekkers "must use a local guide or porter" and that ignoring it "may result in a fine or removal from protected areas". Singapore's own ministry says simply "never trek alone".[4]

NPR 3,000

THE ANNAPURNA CONSERVATION-AREA PERMIT FOR A FOREIGNER; THE INFORMATION CARD IS NPR 2,000 ON THE TRADE ASSOCIATION'S OWN PAGE, AND US$20 ON ANOTHER GOOD SOURCE — THE TWO DO NOT RECONCILE[4]

SOURCES 1 Sah Telee LB, Chaudhary AK, Yadav UK, Karki M, "Monitoring air quality in Kathmandu with trend and public health risks", *Journal of Nepalese Management Academia* 2(1), 2024, pp. 19–30, reporting monthly means from the Ratnapark ground station 2020–2022; **the paper was downloaded and text-extracted by this desk.** 2 Tihar dates read at source on nepcalendar.com, 31 October 2026. **The government holiday window is given variously as 7–12 and 8–12 November across sources and is not printed as a fixed span; Chhath's 2026 date was single-sourced and is omitted.** 3 Route and aircraft from the Flightmapper schedule database, read at source 31 October 2026 — **singaporeair.com returned no usable route listing, so the non-stop is sourced to a schedule aggregator, not to the airline**; fares from Air India's own booking site, read 31 October 2026, and the range is indicative, not a quoted itinerary; airport specifications and the Pokhara and Bhairahawa positions from their own encyclopaedic entries and the cited Kathmandu Post and flydubai reports. 4 UK Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office travel advice for Nepal, safety and security section, read at source 31 October 2026 (still current at that date); Singapore Ministry of Foreign Affairs Nepal page; permit fees from the Trekking Agencies' Association of Nepal's own page and from David Ways, updated 11 January 2026. **Nepal Tourism Board's permit page returned 404 to this desk.**

THE GRAND TOUR · WHERE TO STAY AND EAT

Nepal's tourist arrivals rose 6.2 per cent while Western visitors fell

The tourism board counted 865,920 in the first nine months of 2026; Chinese arrivals more than doubled in September while British numbers fell a quarter and Americans 14 per cent.

Nepal has had a revolution, an election and a new government since this desk last looked, and the visitors have come back anyway. The **Nepal Tourism Board** counted **865,920** arrivals in the first nine months of **2026**, up **6.21 per cent** on the same months of 2025. September alone was **88,248**, up 12.1 per cent on the year before — though still **8.37 per cent** below September 2024. The recovery is real and unfinished.[1]

The composition is what a guidebook will not tell you. In September, arrivals from **China** were **11,212**, more than double the previous year's 5,237. South Asian arrivals rose **23.9 per cent** and now make up more than a third of everyone who comes. Meanwhile **Britain** fell **25.2 per cent**, the **United States 14.3**, Europe as a whole **8.7**, and arrivals from South-East Asia dropped **25.9 per cent**. A Singaporean in the Kathmandu Valley this month will find it markedly less European, and very few of their compatriots.[1]

Where to stay. **Thamel** has the choice and the noise; **Paknajol**, five minutes out, is the compromise. **Boudhanath** is the best case here — a walkable monastic quarter outside the valley bowl. For a real escape from the air, **Shivapuri Heights Cottage** sits at about 1,830 metres on the park boundary, half an hour out, and is the only heritage property in the valley publishing rates: **US$110–250** with breakfast, a tent at **US$45**. In Patan, **Traditional Homes Swotha** from **US$55**; the Summit from **US$145**. Lakeside Pokhara is **NPR 1,200–2,500** for a guesthouse, **NPR 12,000** up for a resort.[2]

Eat Newari, the valley's own cuisine rather than Nepal's general one. **Krishnarpan** at Dwarika's is the formal version at **US$45–120** a head; **Jimbu** in Jhamsikhel at **US$10–22** and **Newa Lahana** at **US$6–14** are the real ones; **Honacha**, behind the Krishna temple on Patan Durbar Square, does buffalo *choyla* for a few hundred rupees, cash only.[3]

PHOTOGRAPHING THE VALLEY · AND THE DARK-SKY ANSWER

Shoot the mountains from the valley rim in the **last week of October**, for the reason on the facing page. **Sarangkot** above Pokhara is the famous dawn viewpoint, **NPR 60** for the tower and free from the Ganesh temple platform — but crowded, and tripods get knocked over on the old fort. **Kaskikot**, hiked and free, is quieter with arguably better views.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · NEPAL'S GOVERNMENT IS SEVEN MONTHS OLD

No government is advising against travel to Nepal, and that is the headline. Singapore's only live notice, dated **27 August 2026**, concerns flooding in Rasuwa, Nuwakot, Dhading, Gorkha and Chitwan — none on this itinerary — and the United Kingdom stood down its Kathmandu family assistance centre on **1 October**. Hold the rest in view. In September 2025 the government shut **26 social-media platforms**; police fired on the protests that followed, and **at least 76 people died in five days**.[5]

US$300–450

A GENUINE TOP-TIER DAY IN NEPAL PER PERSON — THE BEST LODGE, A KRISHNARPAN DINNER, A MOUNTAIN FLIGHT AND A GUIDE. THIS DESK'S OWN ARITHMETIC ON PUBLISHED RATES[6]

SOURCES 1 Nepal Tourism Board monthly arrival figures as reported by The Rising Nepal, 2 October 2026, cross-checked against Nepalnews and Tourism Info Nepal, all three consistent; **October figures were not yet published.** 2 Shivapuri Heights Cottage's own rate page, read at source 31 October 2026; Patan and Pokhara bands from David Ways, pages updated 29 May 2026 and 11 January 2026. **Dwarika's, Baber Mahal Vilas, Tiger Mountain Pokhara Lodge, Temple Tree and the Hyatt publish no rates and none is printed here.** 3 Restaurant price bands from kathmandu.im's restaurant listings, read 31 October 2026 — **the page carries no publication date and is flagged accordingly**; the Patan Newari eateries from a 2022 local article, **four years old and flagged**. 4 Viewpoint detail and access from David Ways' Pokhara, Boudhanath and Patan guides, updated between January and May 2026. **No Bortle class or sky-brightness measurement for Nepal could be verified, and none is printed.** 5 Singapore Ministry of Foreign Affairs Nepal travel page and UK Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office advice, both read at source 31 October 2026; the 2025 protests and the 2026 election from their encyclopaedic entries — **whose own death-toll arithmetic does not reconcile, so the figure is printed as "at least".** 6 Budget tiers, money handling and guide rates from David Ways, pages updated 11 January, 17 and 22 September 2026; **he sells a guide-matching service and guidebooks and promotes them on those pages, and the rates are his own estimates. The top-tier day is this magazine's own addition of published rates. Reddit, TripAdvisor and FlyerTalk all refused this desk, so no forum sentiment appears on these two pages.**

THE DIARY · CHRISTMAS WONDERLAND

Gardens by the Bay confirms Christmas Wonderland for 27 November

Supertree Grove and The Meadow, to 3 January, 6.30pm to 11 — and ticket prices are still unpublished, where a year ago they were already selling from nine dollars.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

1 NOV ★ **Singapore International Film Festival · closing day**
37TH EDITION, RAN FROM 21 OCT · CLOSING FILM *VINTAGE VIOLENCE* · UNDERCURRENT PASS S$50 · **SESSIONS SELL OUT PIECEMEAL; ACCOUNT NEEDED TO BOOK**

3 NOV **yung kai · Asia Tour 2026**
CAPITOL THEATRE, 8PM · GENERAL SALE OPEN · **NO PRICES PUBLISHED ON THE PROMOTER'S PAGE** · VIP PACKAGES AVAILABLE

13–22 Nov **Singapore Writers Festival 2026 · "Hidden in Plain Sight"**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · FESTIVAL PASS **S$30**, YOUTH **S$15** · FIRST-COME-FIRST-SERVED, NON-TRANSFERABLE · **THE FESTIVAL HAS FLAGGED A FRAUDULENT EMAIL IMPERSONATING ITS DIRECTOR**

14 NOV **LUCY · 9th Concert 'ISLAND' Encore**
CAPITOL THEATRE, 6PM · **S$138–218** EXCL. FEES · PRESALES RAN IN AUGUST; GENERAL SALE OPEN

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · **OPENING PERFORMANCE 20 NOV FREE** · *SONGS OF THE BULBUL* FROM S$39.60 · *PAATI'S SPICE KITCHEN* 21–22 NOV FROM S$40, THE FAMILY PICK

28–29 Nov **BABYMONSTER · World Tour [CHOOM]**
SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM, 6PM BOTH NIGHTS · **$168–358** ACROSS EIGHT TIERS EXCL. FEES · **DEEP INVENTORY; THE CHEAP TIERS GO FIRST**

27 NOV ★ **Christmas Wonderland 2026**
SUPERTREE GROVE & THE MEADOW, TO 3 JAN 2027 · 6.30–11PM, LAST ENTRY 10.15 · **"TICKET PRICES WILL BE RELEASED SOON" — NOT YET ON SALE** · FLYING SANTA, BLIZZARD TIME AT THE SPALLIERA

30 NOV **Malcolm Todd · Do That Again Tour**
THE STAR THEATRE, 8PM · **LISTED UNDER GENERAL SALE — THE PROMOTER DOES NOT SAY SOLD OUT, WHATEVER A ROUND-UP CLAIMS**

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

26 Oct–4 Nov ★ **Tokyo International Film Festival · 39th edition**
HIBIYA, YURAKUCHO, MARUNOUCHI AND GINZA · **TICKETS ON SALE; THE YURAKUCHO CENTRE IS THE WALK-UP, OPEN TO 20 MINUTES AFTER THE LAST SCREENING · CINEMA BOX OFFICES DO NOT SELL FESTIVAL TICKETS**

1–25 Nov **Kichirei Kaomise Ô-Kabuki**
KABUKIZA, GINZA · DARK 9 AND 17 NOV · DAY BILL 11AM TO ABOUT 3.41PM, EVENING 4.30 · **SINGLE-ACT *MAKUMI* TICKETS ARE THE WAY IN WITH A CHILD** · PRICES NOT LISTED ON THE THEATRE'S PAGE

8–22 Nov **Grand Sumo · Kyushu Basho — sold out**
FUKUOKA KOKUSAI CENTER · **"SOLD OUT ALL DATES" AND NO DAY-OF SALES** · THE PLAY IS THE **JANUARY TOKYO TOURNAMENT, ADVANCE SALE OPENS SAT 5 DEC**

14–15 Nov ★ **Design Festa vol. 64**
TOKYO BIG SIGHT, WEST AND SOUTH HALLS, 10AM–6PM · **ADVANCE ¥800, DOOR ¥1,000, TWO-DAY ¥1,500 ADVANCE ONLY · ELEMENTARY AGE AND UNDER FREE** · NO REFUNDS, CHECK THE DATE BEFORE BUYING AT A CONVENIENCE STORE

11–16 Nov **Ikenobo Autumn Tanabata Exhibition**
IKENOBO HEADQUARTERS AND THE DAIMARU MUSEUM, KYOTO · **¥1,000 AT THE DOOR, ONE TICKET FOR BOTH VENUES, FREE TO HIGH-SCHOOL AGE AND UNDER** · THE DESCENDANT OF A 1626 IMPERIAL GATHERING (P15)

14–15 Nov **Ikenobo Sasaki Jiyûka COLLECTION 2026**
WEST18 BUILDING, KYOTO, 10AM–5PM · **FREE** · 85 FREE-STYLE ARRANGEMENTS BY 85 ARRANGERS; THE SCHOOL PITCHES IT AT FIRST-TIMERS

7–11 Nov **Tihar · Nepal's festival of lights**
KATHMANDU VALLEY · **LAXMI PUJA SUN 8 NOV, MHA PUJA AND THE NEWAR NEW YEAR TUE 10 NOV**, BHAI TIKA WED 11 · THE GOVERNMENT HOLIDAY RUNS ROUGHLY 8–12 NOV (P21)

SOURCES 1 Every event above was read at the promoter's, venue's or festival's own page on 31 October 2026: Gardens by the Bay's Christmas Wonderland 2026 page; the Singapore International Film Festival; Live Nation Singapore for yung kai, LUCY, BABYMONSTER and Malcolm Todd; the Singapore Writers Festival's own passes page; Esplanade's Kalaa Utsavam programme; the Tokyo International Film Festival's own ticket page; Kabuki-bito for the Kabukiza; the Japan Sumo Association's official ticket service; Design Festa's own ticket page; and Ikenobo's own exhibition pages. 2 The 2025 Christmas Wonderland comparison — 29 November 2025 to 1 January 2026, advance adult from S$9 — from the organiser's own 2025 annex. **Several strong leads were dropped for want of a primary source: Ticketmaster Singapore and SISTIC both refused this desk, so concerts reported elsewhere for 4, 10–11, 20, 22 and 25 November are not listed here. The Standard Chartered Singapore Marathon 2026 is not listed because its own site still carries the 2025 edition.**

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW OPENINGS

Calendar Coffee and Nook Coffee open in Chinatown and Bedok

A Yunnan restaurant has landed at Jewel and a Shanghai coconut-water chain opens at ION in mid-November — and not one of the four has been reviewed by anybody.

A blunt warning before the recommendations, because it is the honest state of the month: **every venue on this page is between three days and three weeks old, or has not opened yet.** None has been reviewed by the Michelin guide, Tatler, Time Out Singapore, Honeycombers or the two big local food sites. The only coverage that exists is Eatbook's opening write-ups, which are announcements carrying no verdict. Where this page says a place is good, it is reporting what is on the menu and what it costs — not a judgment nobody has yet earned the right to make.[1]

Calendar Coffee, at 258 South Bridge Road two minutes from Maxwell station, opened in mid-October from the team behind June Coffee. It is desserts and drinks only — no mains — in a deliberately cluttered cottage room, open Tuesday to Sunday, 11am to 6pm. The distinctive thing is a French toast line: apple pie at **$11**, blueberry cheesecake **$12**, smoked salmon and cream cheese **$14**. Chiffon slices are **$12** in black sesame, earl grey strawberry or banoffee. The drinks are where the thought went: roasted rice latte **$9**, jasmine apple americano **$8.50**, miso caramel hojicha **$9**, osmanthus mochi matcha **$9.50**. No reservations, and Eatbook warns it gets crowded.[2]

Nook Coffee — registered as Nook.57 — is three days old at press time, a hole-in-the-wall at 57A New Upper Changi Road, ten minutes from Tanah Merah, open daily 7.30am to 5. Hand-painted signage, hand-drawn cups. Black from **$3.40**, white from **$3.90**, flavoured lattes from **$4.40**; the signatures are a tiramisu latte at **$5.80** with house-made cream, a mint cocoa latte at **$5.60** and a coconut with coffee foam at **$5.80**. No pork and no lard, though it is not halal-certified. The owners are not named anywhere, which is a gap. Sip the foam before you stir it in.[3]

At Jewel Changi, **Shan Li You** has taken #02-217 with Yunnan cooking — porcini, truffle and egg rice; a wild-pepper and sour-fruit beef soup; lychee sweet-and-sour pork served with a whole passionfruit. The detail that marks the place out is a pot of tea brewed at the table for **$1.90** a head, minimum two, in Yunnan rose, golden chrysanthemum, sticky rose green or rice pu'er. Full prices are not published; Eatbook had not seen the menu. And in mid-November **Yee3**, a Shanghai-born coconut-water chain with more than five hundred outlets, opens its first Singapore counter at ION Orchard, B4-70.[4]

THE BUZZ · TOO NEW TO CALL, AND SAYING SO

This is what the record actually holds. **Yee3** has drawn queues in Kuala Lumpur and Sydney, which is anticipation rather than reception; there is no Singapore waitlist because there is no Singapore shop. **Shan Li You** has no food-media verdict at all, and the only evaluative language anywhere attaches to the lychee pork, which early online comment calls the favourite. **Calendar Coffee**'s crowd warning is Eatbook's, not a queue anyone has measured. **Nook Coffee** has no queue, no waitlist and no soft-launch history; Edna Low called it "adorable" and the prices "a steal in this economy", and that is one writer's line in an opening notice, not a review.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT GOT CUT FROM THE TABLE

Four openings is a thin month, and the reason is worth printing. This desk discarded more than fifty candidates — the ones every round-up is running — because its own ledger records them as already covered twice. It also threw out three places being sold as new that are not: a Faber Drive café reviewed on **9 September**, a Bugis fish-soup outlet that opened in **July**, and a Raffles City shop that opened on **17 December 2025** and is still appearing on "new openings&[6]

SOURCES 1 Michelin Guide Singapore, Tatler Asia, Time Out Singapore, Honeycombers, SETHLUI and HungryGoWhere were all checked for each venue on 31 October 2026 and carry nothing on any of them. 2 Edna Low, Eatbook, 15 October 2026, read at source. 3 Edna Low, Eatbook, 28 October 2026, read at source. 4 Edlyn Yeo, Eatbook, 15 and 30 October 2026, read at source. **Shan Li You's exact opening date is not stated at source — Eatbook called it a recent arrival on 15 October — and its parent group beyond "Yunnan" is not disclosed.** 5 All attributions as published in the Eatbook pieces above. **Reddit and Burpple both refused this desk, so no forum or social sentiment appears on this page.** 6 The discards are this magazine's own Table ledger, which bars a venue after two runs seven issues apart; the three mis-dated openings were each checked against a dated local source.

THE UNDERCURRENT · SOUTH KOREA

South Korea pays shrinking counties for visitors who stay three hours

The "living population" counts anyone present three hours in a month. In Yangyang it outnumbers residents 17.6 to one — and this year it entered the formula for the country's largest block grant.

There is a word in South Korean officialdom that has quietly changed what it means to belong to a place. **생활인구** — *saenghwal-ingu*, "living population" — counts, for each of the country's designated shrinking districts, not only the people registered as living there but everyone else who turned up and stayed a while. The threshold for "a while" is set in a ministerial notice: **three hours, once in a calendar month**, maximum one count a day. Three hours is a lunch and a drive.[1]

It is not a survey. The state *buys* the number — pseudonymised base-station records from the three mobile carriers and transaction records from six card companies, joined together quarterly, for about **₩2.25 billion** a year. South Korea is the only country this desk can find that has made commercially sourced location and spending telemetry a direct input to how it hands out money.[2]

Because from this year it is money. The **보통교부세**, the ordinary local allocation grant, is the largest unconditional transfer from Seoul to local government — the 2027 budget line for local allocation in total is **₩77.19 trillion**, up 11.3 per cent. Within it, a regional-balance component used to be weighted on "floating population × 20 per cent". It is now "**living population × 10 per cent**". The weight halved and the base exploded, because the living population of these districts runs at roughly five times their registered population.[3]

The Gangwon Research Institute has put a figure on what that one variable did for one province: **₩25.1 billion**, of which ₩20.07bn spread across its twelve shrinking counties and ₩5.02bn to the province — the largest provincial gain in the country, ahead of Jeonnam's ₩4.03bn and Gyeongbuk's ₩2.92bn. Hongcheon took ₩3.18bn, Pyeongchang ₩2.71bn, Goseong ₩2.41bn, Yangyang ₩2.32bn.[4]

The numbers underneath are genuinely strange. The **second-quarter 2026** calculation, published jointly by the data authority and the interior ministry on **29 October** — three days ago — gives a monthly-average living population of **28,598,000** against a registered population, in the same districts, of **4,682,000**. The staying population rose **656,000** year on year. The registered population *fell* by 20,000. In May the multiple was **5.8**; in Yangyang county it was **17.6**, in Gapyeong 15.6, in Ongjin 15.3. Gapyeong alone counted **998,000** people staying.[5]

> ***Three hours, once a month, counted once a day. That is the threshold at which a stranger becomes part of a county's population for the purpose of its budget.***

And the counties have responded exactly as a formula predicts. **Gimje City**, with about 80,000 registered residents and a grant-relevant living population near 330,000, has set itself a target of **500,000** and reviews departmental progress toward it; its mayor **Jung Sung-ju** told a 2025 progress review with 37 department heads that expanding it was the core task deciding the city's future. Counties across the country have built "workation" centres and issued digital tourism resident cards.[6]

SOURCES 1 Special Act on Support for Population-Decline Areas, promulgated 10 June 2022, in force 1 January 2023, Article 2(2); the three-hour threshold is in the Ministry of the Interior and Safety public notice 2023-33 on the detailed requirements of the living population, with the enforcement decree setting a maximum of one stay counted per day. Ministry page read at source. 2 The data-purchase budget of ₩2.248bn for 2025, ₩848m more than the prior year, from the National Assembly Budget Office's analysis of the 2025 budget bill as reported by Newsis, 8 November 2024. 3 Kangwon Domin Ilbo, 29 September 2026, page one, reporting the formula change and the 2027 local allocation budget line. 4 Gangwon Research Institute, Policy Talk No. 52, "Local finances grown larger by reflecting the living population", 15 October 2026, as reported by Kangwon Domin Ilbo. 5 Joint announcement of the second-quarter 2026 living-population calculation by the national data authority and the interior ministry, 29 October 2026, as reported by Dailian the same day. 6 Jeonbuk Ilbo, 2 September 2025.

What makes this more than a quirky statistic is that the two halves of South Korea's policy now point in opposite directions, and nobody in Seoul appears to have noticed. The state still *designates* a district as shrinking by its registered population — that is what the map published on **7 October 2026** measures, when the interior minister **Yun Ho-jung** redrew it for the first time in five years, taking the count of population-decline areas from 89 to **92**. But it increasingly *pays* those districts by their staying population. The machine therefore rewards a county for being emptied and, simultaneously, for being crowded.[1]

Yangyang at 17.6 to one is not, under this reading, a success story. It is the equilibrium the formula selects for.

The sharpest evidence that this is real and not theoretical arrived three weeks ago, from the one county that did the thing the whole apparatus is supposed to encourage. **Yeonggwang**, in South Jeolla, raised its registered population from **51,750 in 2023 to 53,608** by September 2026, and has had the highest fertility rate in the country for seven consecutive years — **1.79** in 2025. The October map rewarded it with a new category, "Population Vitality Plus", which keeps its existing support for five years rather than cutting it off at once.[1]

On **20 October** its mayor, **Jang Se-il**, went to the National Assembly's agriculture committee to complain. The 2027 rural basic-income pilot — 52 county governments competing, about 18 to be chosen, selected residents receiving local vouchers worth **₩150,000** a month — awards **ten points for extinction risk and nothing at all for demographic improvement**. Yeonggwang's fiscal independence is **11.9 per cent**; a third of its people are over 65. Having succeeded, it is now scored down for it. The committee chair, **Seo Sam-seok**, agreed reform was needed.[2]

The pull of the new metric shows in what it has displaced. A Money Today editorial in August 2026, arguing for exactly this pivot, supplied the figures that make the case: local governments' cash childbirth payments rose **17 per cent** year on year to **₩1.1457 trillion**, having passed a trillion for the first time the year before, with some municipalities offering up to **₩100 million** for a third child. It conceded two embarrassments in the same breath — prosecutions for **fraudulent residence registration** to claim those payments, and the fact that much of the population "gain" in basic-income pilot areas came from the next district along.[5]

Against that, a visitor who stays three hours commits no fraud and moves nobody's registration. The measure is cheap, it is clean, and it goes up. The apparatus it feeds is not small: the regional extinction response fund runs at about **₩1 trillion** a year, and the special act carries **44 separate concessions** on top of its tax breaks.[6]

A county is now penalised for winning. Korea built an instrument to fight depopulation and arrived at the point where raising your population costs you points.

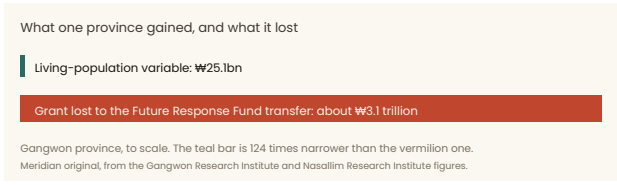
The counter-case is strong and comes from three directions. The **National Assembly Budget Office** said in November 2024 that the exercise had limited practical value: several findings from the pilot were knowable without it — tourist areas have many visitors; garrison towns skew male — and length-of-stay patterns could be derived from existing regional product data without buying telephone and card records. It recommended reviewing whether monthly nationwide calculation was worth the cost.[3]

The second objection is about fairness, and it is the one local newspapers press hardest. Living population tracks proximity to cities and tourism, not distress. Geochang county has **59,588** registered residents and about **177,827** living; Namhae has **39,832** against **238,683**; Yeongdeok **33,210** against **267,800**. Rank the counties by need and then by the new metric and the order reverses. The eighteen districts on the lesser "watch" list are excluded from the calculation altogether, which is why Sokcho's council passed a resolution to the presidential office calling it a serious fairness problem.[4]

SOURCES 1 Segye Ilbo, 7 October 2026, on the redesignation, with English confirmations in the Korea Times and Korea JoongAng Daily the same day; Yeonggwang's population and fertility figures from the Seoul Economic Daily's English edition, 27 October 2026. 2 Seoul Economic Daily, 27 October 2026, reporting Jang Se-il's 20 October appearance before the National Assembly's Agriculture, Food, Rural Affairs, Oceans and Fisheries Committee. 3 National Assembly Budget Office analysis of the 2025 budget bill as reported by Newsis, 8 November 2024; the experimental-series caveats are carried in the quarterly releases themselves. 4 Gyeongnam Ilbo, 17 July 2025, reporting the county-level comparison and the Sokcho resolution. 5 Money Today editorial, 3 August 2026. 6 Segye Ilbo, 7 October 2026, on the fund and the special act's concessions.

The third objection is the devastating one, and it is that everybody is arguing about the slices while the loaf is removed. **Lee Sang-min** of the Nasallim Research Institute published the arithmetic on **1 September 2026**. The government has created a Future Response Fund and taken the transfer to it out of the internal-tax base on which the local allocation grant is calculated. His figures: the 2027 ordinary grant as budgeted is **₩67.58 trillion**; without that transfer, about **₩97.2 trillion**. The difference is roughly **₩29.6 trillion** — the grant grows two per cent instead of 46.7 while national tax revenue rises about 40.7. By province he puts the reduction at **₩4.7tn** for Gyeongbuk, ₩3.8tn Jeonnam, ₩3.4tn Gyeongnam, **₩3.1tn Gangwon**.[1]

Set the two numbers side by side and the ratio is the story. The living-population variable gave Gangwon **₩25.1 billion**. The fund transfer takes about **₩3.1 trillion** off it. That is **124 to one** — this magazine's own arithmetic on the two published figures. A sceptic can say, with numbers, that the whole apparatus is a rounding error dressed as a reform.[2]



The gain and the loss, drawn to scale. A county chasing three-hour visitors is competing for the thinner bar.

That strengthens the argument rather than weakening it: the smaller the pot, the harder every county chases the one variable it can still move. And one researcher has said aloud what the loop is for. **Jeong Yeong-ho** of the Gangwon Research Institute argues the living population should be treated as a *fiscal* instrument rather than a tourism one, with targets set on its size, on length of stay and on the resulting grant effect, and the extra money reinvested in attracting more stays. Spend grant money to generate the footfall that generates grant money.[3]

Japan has run this experiment under another name. **ふるさと納税**, the hometown tax, has let people outside a municipality determine its revenue since 2008, and in the year to March 2025 moved **¥1.2728 trillion** across **58.8 million** donations, a fifth consecutive record. Then in June 2026 Japan's Board of Audit reported that for the same year the municipalities collectively ran an **¥86.3 billion deficit** on it: **¥503.8bn** of net receipts against **¥590.1bn** spent soliciting them. They paid more to acquire the metric than it was worth.[4]

A state that measures belonging in three-hour increments has conceded something it has not said aloud: that it no longer expects these places to be inhabited, only used.

Korea is roughly where Japan stood in 2013, with one difference that makes it worse: the hometown tax moves earmarked donations, the living population moves the unconditional grant, and what it rewards is not a gift catalogue but a three-hour visit. Korea's own catalogue is already visible. A public broadcaster in Chungbuk found in April 2026 that **Danyang's workation centre had three users in a year**, and that Goesan's digital tourism resident card had issued over **190,000** cards at a usage rate of **2.4 per cent**. A frequent visitor it interviewed had never used his and did not know what it was.[5]

The argument has dates on which it can fail. If the interior ministry's December allocation moves the living-population item less than about **₩100 billion** nationally, the variable is decoration. If the third-quarter release drops the multiple back toward three, the five-times figures were a holiday artefact. And if Jang Se-il wins his point and improvement starts scoring, the contradiction is corrected. Until then the instrument stands as built: presence has been monetised, residence has not, and the **Western press has not written a word of it**.[6]

SOURCES 1 Lee Sang-min, Nasallim Research Institute, Nara Salim Report briefing No. 512, 1 September 2026, revised 6 September, read at source. 2 **The 124-to-one ratio is this magazine's own arithmetic** on the Gangwon Research Institute's ₩25.1bn and Lee's ₩3.1tn. 3 Jeong Yeong-ho, Gangwon Research Institute, 15 October 2026, as reported by Kangwon Domin Ilbo. 4 Japan's Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications survey published 31 July 2025, as reported by Akita Sakigake Shimpo; the Board of Audit finding as reported by Kyodo via Kumamoto Nichinichi Shimbun, 12 June 2026. 5 KBS Cheongju, reporter Lee Gyu-myeong, 24 April 2026, the closing instalment of a series on local population policy. 6 Outlets checked for a feature on the living-population statistic or its use in the grant formula: the New York Times, BBC, Reuters, Financial Times, The Economist, Bloomberg, Associated Press, Wall Street Journal and The Guardian. **Nothing from any of the nine. All nine block this desk's search crawler at the domain level, so the check was run through open searches that would surface them if they had published; confidence is high but not absolute.**

THE LAST WORD

The stand-in

A caliper that reads to a hundredth of a millimetre is accurate to two hundredths. The standard says so; the makers print both numbers; and the last digit on the screen is a digit the tool cannot stand behind (p6). That is the shape of the whole issue. Somewhere between the thing you care about and the thing you can count, a stand-in gets accepted — and then the stand-in is what gets paid, graded, bought and governed.

Gold's textbook driver moved in gold's favour all October — the ten-year real yield fell twenty-eight basis points — and gold fell anyway (p14). Alphabet lost half a trillion dollars on a quarter in which revenue grew a quarter and the margin widened; what missed was a line below the operating result, an eight-point-seven-billion-dollar mark on shares it happens to own (p4). A steroid injection buys six weeks of a tendon score and costs eight points of it by six months (p18). Exercise raises a protein in the blood, and the meta-analysis that confirms it says the blood licenses no claim about the brain.

And in South Korea the stand-in has been written into law. A county's population, for the purpose of the largest grant Seoul pays, now includes everyone who spent three hours inside it once in a month — bought from the phone companies and the card companies for two and a quarter billion won a year. In Yangyang the counted outnumber the resident seventeen to one. The county that actually raised its birth rate is scored down for it (p25). Presence has been monetised. Residence has not.

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SOURCES **A note on method.** This edition's load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves; Alphabet's and Intel's own results filings; the European Central Bank's decision and press-conference transcript; Singapore's environment agency, law ministry, home affairs ministry and monetary authority, each on its own site; the Ministry of Manpower's gazetted holiday list; a peer-reviewed Nepali air-quality paper, downloaded and text-extracted; Japan's agriculture ministry flower report, likewise; Korean government releases and research-institute briefings as carried by the Korean press; four journals at their publishers; a public code repository's own releases and pull requests; makers' and retailers' own storefronts in nine currencies; and the venue, promoter or festival page for every dated event on p23. **Figures that are this magazine's own arithmetic say so where they appear** — the ten-year breakeven and the 2s10s spread on p14, the Woodpeckers conversion on p6, the Ryūsei-ha licence total on p17, the Louis Erard price rise on p10, and the 124-to-one ratio on p27. Where a host refused us — **Reddit for the seventeenth issue running, and so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; also the New York Times, bmj.com, Metacritic, TripAdvisor, FlyerTalk, Burpple, Watchuseek, Hodinkee, Practical Machinist, the Garage Journal, Channel NewsAsia, The Straits Times, X, the LBMA price file, Singapore Airlines' own site, Instagram and YouTube** — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. **Wikimedia Commons fetched in-session for the first time since No. 148, and every photograph in this issue was downloaded and looked at before it was captioned.**